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ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

Teachers and students of Lingasaini Secondary School in Khandachakra Municipality of Kalikot district paying tributes to martyrs on the occasion of Martyrs Day on Tuesday.

Martyrs source of inspiration: PM



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' said that Martyr's Day was the day to reaffirm the dreams of martyrs and their remaining revolutionary works.

Speaking at a programme organised on the occasion of the Martyr's Day at the Martyrs Memorial Lainchaur on Tuesday, The Prime Minister said, "The martyrs have made great sacrifices for the political, economic, social, cultural transformation and inclusive democracy establishment of Nepali society. The martyrs who sacrificed their lives struggling for nationality, democracy and people's livelihood remain a source of inspiration and guidance for all of us, in the past, present, and future."

On the occasion, Prime Minister Prachanda paid tribute to martyrs Shukraraj Shastri, Dharmabhakta Mathema, Dashrath Chand and Gangalal Shrestha who sacrificed their lives fighting against the Rana regime for the establishment of democracy in 1941.

In memory of all disappeared warriors, the Prime Minister said, "I wish for health recovery and long life to the injured warriors."

Earlier in a message issued on the occasion, Prime Minister Prachanda said that Magh 16 (10th month of Nepali calendar), was a day to honour and remember the martyrs who sacrificed their lives for the self-respect and independence of Nepal and Nepalis.

He said, "The martyrs, who made high sacrifices for the political, economic, social, cultural transformation and the establishment of inclusive democracy in Nepali society, are a source of inspiration for all of us. They will remain as an inspiration all the time."

The message read that the government declared the individuals who received immorality in different time periods as national martyrs and had highly prioritised and respected their families.

Similarly, present constitution and republic system were achieved from the revolution from the time of Lakhan Thapa till the Rana regime, 2007 BS revolution, first and second people's movement, 10-year people's war, Madhes movement and others that took place under the leadership of various communities. Therefore, in today's context, protecting and strengthening the achievements and dedicating ourselves to more rights is a true tribute to the great martyrs.

The Martyrs Day was marked across the country from Dhankuta East to Baitadi West.

Meanwhile, the day was marked in Dhankuta by garlanding the statue of martyrs at the Martyrs Memorial amid a programme organised jointly by the Martyrs Concern Society, Martyrs Bhim Narayan Shrestha Memorial Foundation, Martyrs Ram Krishna Shrestha Memorial Foundation, Martyrs Memorial Concerns Study Centre, Dhankuta Martyrs Memorial Foundation and Husadek Nepal Dhankuta.

PM CALLS FOR MAKING UPCOMING HOUSE SESSION EFFECTIVE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has held discussion with the Ministry of Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs (MoLJPA) about giving 'business' to the Parliament that will start its new session from February 5.

Prime Minister Prachanda called the officials of the MoLJPA to the Prime Minister's Office, Singha Durbar, and discussed the preparation of the bills to be presented in the upcoming session of the federal parliament.

During the discussion, the Prime Minister emphasised the need to make the session effective as there were reviews that the previous session of the parliament could not play an effective role in lawmaking.

Directing the Ministry, PM Prachanda said, there is a review that last year the parliament could not do an exemplary job in lawmaking. According to him, there is also an opinion that the government did not give 'business' to the parliament and this time it should not happen again.

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Fast Track project's physical progress 29% in seven years

BY RAM MANI DAHAL
Hetauda, Jan. 30



The Kathmandu-Madhes Fast Track (Expressway) project has achieved only 29 per cent overall physical progress in seven years.

Although there is no obstacle in the construction project site except for one or two places, the progress so far has been quite slow.

The expressway road project, which is one of the national pride projects of the government, was entrusted to Nepali Army six years ago.

The overall physical progress by January 14 this year since the Army took over the project construction has been 29.62 per cent.

The progress of the project up to last mid-October was at 29.19 per cent.

Similarly, the project office has said that the overall financial progress including the mobilisation of the project up to mid-January stood at 30.45 per cent.

According to the overall action plan of the project, out of 13 construction packages, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6 and 7 are under way.

According to the office, international bidding was called for the package no. 8 (A) and 9 (A) on April 21, 2023 and package no. 9 (B) on April 23, and after none of the builders were qualified, the procurement process was canceled and the bids were invited again on July 13, and the bids were opened on August 30 and the bidding is in the process of evaluation. This package site work lies around Sisneri-Makkhubesi of Makwanpur district.

Similarly, the project has signed an agreement with CREGC-COVEC JV for package no. 10 in Mahadevtar section on January 5.

There is an agreement with the research and training unit of Pulchowk Engineering Campus for a detailed feasibility study at the starting point of the expressway in Khokana section under package no. 11. After the report is made available, the land purchase process along the section will also begin, the office said.

The 72.5 km Expressway, which will be the shortest route between Kathmandu and the Tarai, comprises 55.5 km of road, six tunnels with a combined length of 6.41 km, and several bridges measuring a total of 10.59 km.

According to the project, 89 bridges will be constructed under the project, and from package no. 1 to 7, 62 bridges are under construction.

In addition, it is mentioned in the progress report of the project that the construction work of five bridges has been completed till mid-January of the current fiscal.

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Nepal urges Britain for equal pension to Gurkha soldiers

DPM Khadka meets visiting UK Army Chief Patrick Sanders

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka has asked for equal pension and facilities for the Gorkha soldiers.

DPM Khadka requested the Chief of the General Staff of the British Army, General Patrick Sanders, who is on a Nepal visit to take a positive initiative on behalf of Gorkha soldiers regarding their demand to provide equal pension and facilities.

DPM Khadka made this remark with the British Army Chief, who reached the Ministry of Defence in Singha Durbar on Tuesday to have a courtesy meeting with the DPM.

In the meeting, DPM Khadka said that the contribution of the Gurkhas serving in the British Army is incomparable and requested a positive initiative on behalf of them about the demand to provide equal pension and facilities to those who retired before 1997 along with British soldiers.

According to the Secretariat of DPM Khadka, he also requested to show more generosity on behalf of the British government as a bilateral committee has been formed for a mutual solution to the issue and discussions have been going on for a long time but no concrete results have been achieved.

On the occasion, the British Army Chief said that he took seriously the issue raised by Deputy Prime Minister Khadka about the Gurkha soldiers.

DPM Khadka recalled that 10 Nepali troops participated in the Cambrian patrol in October 2023 and also mentioned that the British government's support in establishing an 'Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD)' holding unit for the Nepali army was important.

Nepal's corruption index improves slightly

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Nepal has slightly improved its position in the global Corruption Perception Index (CPI) 2023 with a two-step jump from 110th among 180 countries in 2022 to 108th position in 2023.

According to Transparency International's CPI 2023 report launched globally on Tuesday, Nepal has remained in the group of high corruption perception scoring just 35 in 100. Its score has gone up to 35 this year from 34 last year. In 2013, the country ranked 116th position scoring 31 among 177 countries worldwide.

This shows that Nepal has failed to achieve much success in curbing corruption and is in the groups of countries that have high corruption rates, said the TI Nepal. Nepal is in the club of two-thirds of countries that scored less than 50. The average score of the countries in Asia and the Pacific region is 45.

In South Asia, Bhutan tops the list and remains in the 26th position. India is in 93rd, the Maldives 93rd, Sri Lanka 115th, Pakistan 133rd, Bangladesh 149th and Afghanistan is at 162nd. Nepal's northern neighbour China is in the 76th position with 42 marks.

Despite the progress made in criminalising corruption and establishing specialised anti-corruption institutions around the world, only 28 of the 180 countries measured by the CPI have improved their corruption levels, and 34 countries have worsened.

According to the report, for the sixth year in a row, Denmark heads the ranking, with a score of 90. Finland and New Zealand follow closely with scores of 87 and 85, respectively. Norway (84), Singapore (83), Sweden (82), Switzerland (82), the Netherlands (79), Germany (78) and Luxembourg (78) complete the top 10 this year.

Meanwhile, countries experiencing conflict or with highly restricted freedoms and weak democratic institutions tend to score worse. This year, Somalia (11), Venezuela (13), Syria (13) and South Sudan (13) are at the bottom of the index. Yemen (16), Nicaragua (17), North Korea (17), Haiti (17), Equatorial Guinea (17), Turkmenistan (18) and Libya (18) are the next lowest performers.

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Ritual wedding to save villagers' lives

BY RAJU LAMICHHANE
Rukum West, Jan. 30

A beautiful pond, Sankhadaha, is located in the middle of Sankha village of Musikot Municipality-7 in Rukum West district.

The Sankhadaha separates two settlements -- Mathigaun and Taligaun.

This year, Mathigaun asked Taligaun for the hands of their girl and concluded the ritual wedding ceremony.

As per the custom, the marriage that consists of various rituals like finding the bride, taking the marriage procession, bringing the bride home and throwing a marriage party concludes in three days.

Each year, it is customary to go to ask for the hands of girl on the evening of Magh 14, take the groom with a marriage procession to the bride's home on Magh 15 and return home with the bride in the same evening.

This is not real but a fake marriage. Locals organise it as a part of Papini Mela every year. Both bride and groom are young boy and girl.

The marriage ceremony is performed according to the tradition. Both the girl and boy are dressed like bride and groom.



PHOTO: RAJU LAMICHHANE

A mock ritual wedding ceremony organised for fun in Mathigaun and Taligaun of Rukum West district.

Yakka Bahadur Pandey, Ward Chairperson, said that the marriage ceremony is celebrated for three days with fanfare, but all the procedures are dramatic. The bride and groom are also fake.

The parents of both parties, the people who get married and the people who attend the banquet, are all unmarried girls. These girls are called 'Papini'.

Ward Chair Pandey said that the girls who have preserved the tradition are named 'Papini'. To be a 'Papani', one should be from the tribal community, unmarried and should possess dancing skills.

"The girl who sustains the customs of the village is called 'Papini'. The question as to why the girl, who has been following this practice for ages, is called 'Papini' remains unanswered," said Pandey.

Lal Bahadur Mahat, a local leader, said that this culture is more of a tradition than a compulsion.

The practice of dramatised marriage started in Sankhadaha at the beginning of human settlement in Sankh. According to Mahat, it is widely believed that people will die in the village if they do not continue the dramatic weddings.

Every year, two villages of Sankh prepare the 'Papini' and follow the tradition.

Hitting by nettle (Sisno) and paying a fine

There is also another tradition of hitting the visitors with stinging nettle and paying fines at the Papini fair. Under the guidance of the 'Papini' leader, the process begins from Magh 1. Papini of Taligaun stays in the lower edge of the pond and the Papini of the Mathigaun village stays in the upper edge every night. During this time, it is customary to make a fire, and play with stinging nettle and dance.

The girls stay at every entry point of the village to welcome the guests, mostly men, who come to the fair. They catch each man and hit them with the plants of stinging nettle. If the men cannot escape the girls, they have to pay a fine.

The fine collected thus is spent to manage the marriage. Various cultural and sports programmes are also organised in the fair.

Minister Saud stresses to enhance cooperation between Nepal, SKorea

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud has stressed the need to explore possibilities of economic cooperation between Nepal and the Republic of Korea. Addressing a function organised on the occasion of the 50th anniversary of diplomatic relations between Nepal and Korea on Tuesday, Foreign Minister Saud stressed the need for exploring the areas of trade, economy and investment between the two countries for further strengthening relations between them.

Minister Saud urged the Korean investors to invest in potential sectors, including agriculture and tourism. He said that the government was ready to welcome a large number of Korean investors, industrialists and entrepreneurs at the upcoming investment summit to be held in April in Nepal.

Foreign Minister Saud also said that there was a great possibility of expanding economic cooperation between the two countries. He said, "Let's explore the possibilities of economic partnership between us. Let's increase bilateral trade and investment." He said that partnerships should be strengthened in the fields of agriculture, energy, tourism and information technology.

He said, "There are thousands of Nepali workers in Korea. Nepalis have chosen Korea for further studies. Thousands of Koreans come to Nepal as tourists. A large number of Koreans have invested in Nepal. In the coming days, we will further expand this partnership." Foreign Minister Saud said that the exchange of high-level visits will also be speeded up and said, "I am confident that we can have a high-level visit on the occasion of the Golden Jubilee."



PHOTO:TRN
Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud inaugurating a function organised on the occasion of the 50th anniversary of diplomatic relations between Nepal and Korea in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

He appreciated that the two countries have been closely cooperating in various fields, including the economy, employment, education, and people-to-people exchanges since the establishment of diplomatic ties in 1974 and there shall be further cooperation between the two countries in the future.

The diplomatic relations between the Republic of Korea and Nepal were established in 1974. This year – 2024, marks the 50th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between the two countries.

To celebrate this occasion, the Embassy of the Republic of Korea in Nepal organised the Launching Ceremony of a Commemorative Logo and Book on Success stories after the introduction of the EPS programme on Tuesday.

The commemorative logo to mark the 50th anniversary of Diplomatic Relations between the Republic of Korea and Nepal was unveiled jointly by Foreign Minister Saud and the Ambassador of the Republic of Korea to Nepal, Park Taeyoung.

The logo shall be jointly used by the Embassy of the Republic of Korea and the government of Nepal for the programmes related to Korea. The logo incorporates "50 Years" to mark the 50th anniversary with the colours and elements of the flags of both countries - Korea and Nepal.

The book includes the success stories of 26 Nepali returnees who have successfully established their businesses in Nepal with the help of the skills learned in the Republic of Korea through various programmes such as the Employment Permit System (EPS).

Ambassador Park Taeyoung said that the Embassy would be organising various programmes in the cultural, economic and development areas to commemorate the 50th anniversary of diplomatic ties this year. He said that through the mutual cooperation programmes, the close ties would be further deepened and the bilateral relation between the two countries would reach a new height.

"As we celebrate this golden anniversary, we must also look ahead to the future. Our diplomatic ties have weathered the test of time. Now, more than ever, it is crucial for us to strengthen our cooperation for the challenges and opportunities that lie ahead. The global landscape is ever-changing, and by deepening our collaboration, we can navigate together these changes with resilience and solidity," said the Ambassador.

Over the past five decades, the economic collaboration between Korea and Nepal has evolved into a model of mutually beneficial cooperation, he said. The bilateral labour and employment cooperation between Korea and Nepal has thrived since 2007 with the signing of the bilateral Employment Permit System MoU. Under this initiative, about 100,000 young individuals from Nepal have ventured to Korea enriching both nations.

Secretary of the Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security Kewal Prasad Bhandari praised the priority given by the Korean government to Nepalis in the field of employment and expressed his belief that the skills, experience and knowledge learned by Nepalis in Korea will be useful in the country. He said that the Korean government's contribution to Nepal's development has expanded the friendly and brotherly relationship between the two countries.

NEPAL-KAILASH MANASAROVAR DIRECT FLIGHT RESUMES

RSS
Nepalgunj, Jan. 30

A direct flight from Nepalgunj to Kailash Manasarovar in Tibetan Autonomous Region of China has started Tuesday after several effort. A chartered airplane of Shree Airlines boarding 38 Indian tourists its maiden flight to Kailash Manasarovar Tuesday, informed Keshav Neupane, regional director of the Siddhartha Business Group.

According to him, Indian tourists from several cities flow to Kailash Manasarovar on Tuesday. Dr. Om Mishra, Managing Director of the Mero Planet, expressed his happiness that the flights to Kailash Manasarovar have started after a long hiatus and direct flight between Nepalgunj and Kailash Manasarovar and believed that Nepalgunj has been established as a tourist destination with the operation of this flight.

Nepal Association of Tour and Travels (NATA), Banke Chapter Chairperson Shreeram Sigdel expressed his confidence that the direct flight from Nepalgunj to Kailash Manasarovara would be fruitful for tourism promotion of Nepalgunj.He urged to make flight between Nepalgunj and Pokhara more effective.

A mountain flight has begun from Nepalgunj to Kailash Mansarovar at the initiative of tourism entrepreneurs' associations. Although the flight was scheduled to begin last Saturday, thick fog weakened visibility, resulting into two days delay.

Tourism entrepreneur Keshav Neupane said the mountain flight would help recover declining business and help identify tourism destinations for Indian tourists. "At least one flight for Indian tourists in the season will contribute to boost tourism activities," he believed, adding that view of the Kailash Mansarovar is alluring site indeed.

First thru-hiking from south to north introduced in Nepal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Earthbound Expeditions, a trekking company, has introduced a thru-hiking route connecting Khunuwa, a village along the Nepal-India border in the south, to Rasuwagadhi, a border point of Nepal with China's Kerung in the north.

The hiking route is 440 km long and passes through nine districts in three provinces along three geographies – Tarai, Hill and Himalayas. "The route passes through historical places and major business routes connecting ancient cultural communities in the region," said Rajan Simkhada, president of the company.

According to thru-hiking.com, thru-hiking is walking a long-distance path from start to end. "In most cases, you will cross multiple regions or maybe even several countries. Moreover, if a hiker needs to deviate from the route, for instance, to re-supply, s/he will return to the trail to continue," the website states.

Starting from Khunuwa, the trail passes through Taulihawa, Kapilvastu, Kudan, Jagdishpur Taal, Butawal and Masayam Hatiya to the hills of Tansen. The route then moves forward along Aryabhanjyang, Keladi Ghat, Ghiring, Rishing, Damauli, Bandipur, Gorkha and Borlang.

Through Taari Bensi, Katunje, Meghang, Salme, Gonga, Singla Pass, Pangsang Pass, Somdang and Chilime, the trail ends at Rasuwagadhi.

Simkhada went on the exploration of which he claims to be the first thru-hiking route in Nepal with Mike Obester, a professional thru-hiker in the USA, and two experienced Nepali hikers Chetan Rai and Kaji Sherpa.

"In 17 days, walking 634,635 steps, we reached Rasuwagadhi border point in the Himalayas from Khunuwa, a border point in the Tarai," Simkhada added.

Talking to The Rising Nepal, Mike said, "Starting a hike from a lowland and ending it in high Himalayas was a great experience.

Alongside the geographical differences, and the cultural and religious variations, living in peace and harmony makes the hike a spiritual journey as well. It is a perfect thru-hike route which also provides some of the best natural scenes and knowledge on Nepal's history."

Simkhada informed that aspiring thru-hikers can complete the whole trek in parts as well. "However, you should start walking from the point you left," he stressed.

"More information on the thru-hiking route can be sought at www.thruhikesnepal.com," said Simkhada.

Farmers attracted towards commercial cultivation of cardamom amid peaking price of cash crop

BY GOKUL BHUJEL
Bhojpur, Jan. 30

After starting to get good price for cardamom, the farmers of Bhojpur are now attracted towards cardamom cultivation. Gunaraj Rai of Arun Rural Municipality-2, Champe sold six mans (40 kg) cardamom at a rate of Rs. 60,000 per man this year in Kartik.

He is satisfied even though the price has increased and reached Rs. 85,000 per man at present. Last year, cardamom was sold at the rate of Rs. 20,000 per man, but now the price of cardamom is increasing day by day over the recent months. Rai said, "About 20 mans of cardamom is produced in 30 ropanis of land of the village, and the investment is recovered by selling the cardamom saplings while the rest is profit."

Another local farmer, Laxman Rai, produced about six mans of cardamom in 15 ropanies of land, but he has produced about 3.5 mans of cardamom this year. "Local traders come to our house and purchase cardamom at a good price. We have planted cardamom in the field where we used to produce rice. Cardamom earns better than rice, corn and millet. The income from the sale of cardamom is enough to manage household expenses, children's education and expenses for clothes as well."

He said that as the cardamom is sold at up to Rs. 2,500 per kg, locals of the village along with him have been attracted towards the commercial cardamom cultivation. In the old kilns, there were many problems such as time, firewood consumption, worker's health problems and investment cost. But now, with the new modern kilns provided by the cardamom zone, these problems have been resolved and it is easy to dry the produce, said farmers.



PHOTO: GOKUL BHUJEL/TRN
Prepared Cardamom

The cardamom cultivation needs water from the sky during winter, and irrigation should also be arranged. Along with the lack of irrigation, the production of cardamom is reduced due to the outbreak of various diseases. According to local cardamom trader Shukra Raj Rai, the price of cardamom has been increasing gradually for the past two years.

At present, they have purchased a Dambarsai variety of cardamom at Rs. 85,000 per man reaching farmers' homes. The main reasons to pay high price for cardamom are the low production, along with the modern furnaces used by cardamom farmers to dry cardamom. With the use of modern technology for drying cardamom, the colour of cardamom does not change, the smoke smell is reduced, the weight is not reduced, and the quality is better, so the price has not decreased.

The cardamom farmers are excited about the recent rise in the price of cardamom. The credit goes to the Cardamom Zone Office Bhojpur. It has supported the cardamom farmers in the construction of irrigation infrastructure and modern kilns for drying the cardamom.

Rajesh Bista, the district president of the Cardamom Traders Association, said, "Drying cardamom in modern kilns has enhanced the quality of cardamom, weight, ease of storage and sale and distribution." He said that they would urge the federal, provincial and local governments for the labeling, packaging and branding of cardamom to make cardamom cultivation more commercial.

According to the Cardamom Zone Office, 98 farmer groups and agricultural firms of Bhojpur district have been involved in the Cardamom Zone programme and are cultivating cardamom. The zone office Bhojpur has been conducting the programme by linking the farmer groups engaged in cardamom cultivation with it.

According to it, cardamom cultivation is being done in 723 hectares in the district, and cardamom has started to produce in the 665 hectares of land. At the rate of 0.42 tonnes per hectare, 279.3 tonnes of cardamom has been produced this year, said Kaushila Bista, chief of the Prime Minister Agriculture Modernisation Project, Project Implementation Unit Sankhuwasabha Zone Technical Unit, Bhojpur. According to Bista, the programme of cardamom zone is operating in 30 wards of six local levels in Bhojpur.

Coffee cultivation attracts East Nawalparasi farmers

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kawasoti. Jan. 30

The number of farmers cultivating coffee in the hilly villages of East Nawalparasi has started increasing. Farmers who started coffee cultivation with little investment have now started doing it commercially. Farmers said that they were attracted towards commercial coffee farming over the years as its production is getting better and the income is increasing.

Purna Singh Rana Magar, vice-chairman of Hupsekot Rural Municipality, said that farmers are now attracted towards coffee cultivation in the hilly villages of Hupsekot Rural Municipality, Dandajheri, Kotthar, Jaubari of Bulingtar Rural Municipality and Naram, Ruchanga, Babak, Dhaubadi of Baudikali Rural Municipality.

Kamala Gurung of Baudikali Rural Municipality has been cultivating coffee for four years. Gurung, who has planted around 300 coffee plants, said that she earns a good income from it. She said that this year coffee cultivation is better than last year in hilly areas and farmers are satisfied with coffee farming.



Tulisara Rana Magar of Hupsekot Rural Municipality has cultivated 200 coffee plants. Stating that the coffee can be planted in the cold areas of the hills and it was giving good income, Ranamagar said that she is planning to expand coffee farming next year.

The commercial coffee is cultivated in 11 hectares in Nawalpur district, according to the statistics of Agricultural Knowledge Centre. About 500 farmers are involved in coffee farming in the district. The per hectare production of coffee stood at 0.8 tonnes.

A two-day training has also been conducted in Kawasoti for the scientific, sustainable and commercial production and productivity of coffee in this district, which has a lot of potential for coffee cultivation. The aim of the training is to educate potential farmers about opportunities and benefits of coffee production and motivate them to engage in its farming commercially.

Dr. Badri Prasad Bastakoti, an expert from EU-Nepal Trade and Investment Programme, said that this kind of training was organised to increase the awareness of the farmers concerned to exploit the potential of coffee in Nepal.

Bhaktaraj Joshi, Under Secretary of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, said that if the National Tea and Coffee Development Board was to advance the production enhancement programme with cooperation and coordination with the local levels, it would be easy to increase the production of Nepali coffee.

He said that the government has carried out the plans to promote exports with various concessional programmes. The coffee is cultivated in about 3,655 hectares of land in about 42 districts in Nepal. According to government statistics, around 394 tonnes of coffee was produced in the last fiscal year 2022/23. In the last fiscal year, Nepal exported 77 tonnes of coffee worth Rs. 134 million and imported 450 tonnes of coffee worth Rs. 325 million.

NILGIRI II HYDROPOWER PROJECT COMPLETED

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

The construction of Nilgiri Khola II Cascade hydropower project with a capacity of 71 MW has been completed in Narchang, Annapurna rural municipality-4 of Myagdi.

It is the largest hydropower project constructed in Myagdi so far. The test of power generation will be done by pouring water into the tunnel from today, said Upendraraj Gautam, the representative of Nilgiri Khola Hydropower Company Limited, the promoter company of the project. A 4,275 meter long tunnel has been constructed from Chotepa to the power house in Dovilna.

British Army Chief Sanders in Nepal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Chief of the General Staff of the British Army Patrick Nicholas Yardley Monrad Sanders arrived in Nepal on a five-day official visit on Monday at the invitation of Chief of the Army Staff (CoAS) General Prabhu Ram Sharma.

The two army chiefs held a meeting on Tuesday.

According to Brigadier General and Director at the Directorate of Public Relations and Information, Krishna Prasad Bhandari, matters of mutual interest including the century-old mutual relationship between Nepal and the United Kingdom of Great Britain and the harmonious relationship between the armies of the two countries were discussed in the meeting held on Tuesday morning.

Before the courtesy meeting, a troop of the Nepali army paid a guard of honour to the British Army Chief at the Army Headquarters.

The Chief of the British Army was received at the Tribhuvan International Airport by Lieutenant General and Chief of the General Staff (CGS) Ashok Raj Sigdel on Monday. He will remain in Nepal till February 3.



PHOTO: TRN

Visiting British Army Chief receiving guard of honour at the Army Headquarters in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

Dhurkot gets best score in institutional capacity

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gulmi, Jan. 30

Of two municipalities and 10 rural municipalities in Gulmi district, Dhurkot Rural Municipality has achieved the highest score in the Local Government Institutional Capacity Self-Assessment (LISA).

According to the LISA result based on the work evaluation of the Fiscal Year 2022/023, Dhurkot stood first by obtaining 93.75 per cent followed by Chandrakot and Rurukshetra rural municipalities at 93.25 per cent and Musikot Municipality at 91.5 per cent.

Similarly, Madane Rural Municipality achieved 91.25 per cent, Resunga Municipality 90.25 per cent, Kaligandagi Rural Municipality 90 per cent, Malika Rural Municipality 88.5 per cent, Satyawati Rural Municipality 88 per cent, Gulmi Darbar Rural Municipality 86.25 per cent, Isma Rural Municipality 85.5 per cent and Chhatrakot Rural Municipality 82.25 per cent.

Rurukshetra Rural Municpality's chief administrative officer Laxman Pandey informed that the evaluation was carried out in accordance with the LISA Guideline-2078 BS. He added that the evaluation was carried out in 10 different areas, including governmental management, organisation and administration, annual budget and plan management, financial and economic management, service delivery, judicial performance, physical infrastructure, social inclusion, environmental conservation and disaster management, coordination and collaboration. The results were presented in the assessment of 100 indicators for each area.

Since the Fiscal Year 2019/020, the evaluation has been carried out to identify strengths and weaknesses of work procedures and achievements of the local levels.

Rurukshetra Rural Municpality's chief administrative officer Laxman Pandey informed that the evaluation was carried out in accordance with the LISA Guideline-2078 BS.

Thatched roofs being replaced with corrugated iron sheets

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Banepa, Jan. 30

The thatched roofs of houses in three local levels of the Kavrepalanchok district are being replaced with sheets of corrugated metal in the current fiscal year with the subsidy provided by the Safe Citizen Housing Programme.

Santosh Kumar Niraula, the chief engineer of the Urban Development and Building Office in Kavrepalanchok, said that under the Safe Citizen Housing Programme, the traditional thatched roofs in Chaurideurali, Khanikhola and Temal Rural Municipalities were being replaced with corrugated sheets in the current fiscal year.

The thatched roofs of 87 houses in Temal Rural Municipality, 57 houses in Khanikhola Rural Municipality and 52 houses in Chaurideurali Rural Municipality will be replaced this year.

"We asked the local levels of Kavrepalanchok, Sindhupalchowk and Dolakha districts in the last fiscal year to provide the data of the houses having thatched roofs in their municipalities. Two districts did not send the data, and among the 13 rural municipalities in the Kavrepalanchok, we received the data only from three rural municipalities" said Niraula.

He said that Rs. 60,000 would be provided to each family which replaced their thatched roofs with corrugated sheets. The office has allocated Rs. 11.7 million to replace the thatched roofs. The programmme is being carried out as per the government's strategy to eliminate thatched roofs.

According to the data provided by Chaurideurali Rural Municipality, Ward No. 2 and 3 have one house each with thatched roofs. Likewise, 10 houses in Ward.no 5 and 40 houses in Ward. No 7 in the rural municipality have thatched roofs.

Similarly, nine houses in Ward No. 4, 38 houses in Ward No. 5, and 10 houses in Ward No. 6 in the Khanikhola Rural Municipality have thatched roofs.

Likewise, 29 houses in Ward No. 4, four houses in Ward No. 5, 16 houses in Ward No. 6 and 38 houses in Ward No. 8 in the Temal Rural Municipality have thatched roofs.

To respect, protect and fulfil the rights to safe and environment-friendly housing, the government has started the work of replacing thatched roofs with zinc sheets by issuing Safe Citizen Housing Implementation Procedure-2075 BS for the purchase of materials including zinc sheets and providing subsidies to purchase wood if the families living below the poverty line want to construct safe houses.

Cold weather causing respiratory ailments among children



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHERAL/TRN

Patients getting checkups in the hospital as seen in the picture.

BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 30

The enduring cold weather in Jhapa is causing respiratory ailments among children.

Jaymani Shrestha, the Medical Superintendent (MESU) and a paediatrician at KIOCH Children's Hospital in Damak highlighted that a majority of children seeking treatment at the hospital are diagnosed with pneumonia, bronchiolitis and asthma.

Shrestha explained that pneumonia, primarily a lung-related problem, involves infections in one or both lungs, typically caused by viruses, bacteria, or fungi. Timely treatment is crucial, as delayed intervention can pose a serious threat to a child's life.

Similarly, bronchiolitis, a condition that develops when the airways in the lungs, called bronchial tubes, become inflamed, is commonly observed in young children and infants, especially those aged below two years.

Parents often rush their wheezing and breathless children to the emergency department, often after oxygen deficiency becomes severe. Shrestha emphasised that immediate monitoring and placement in the High Dependency Unit (HDU) or Neonatal Intensive Care Unit (NICU) are essential in such cases.

Asthma, attributed to lung allergies, is a prevalent respiratory problem among children. Shrestha noted that timely intervention can effectively control asthma attacks and minimise long-term effects on the lungs.

KIOCH Damak Children's Hospital, operating as a 50-bed provincial hospital under the leadership of Dr. Bhagwan Koirala, is currently grappling with an influx of 50 to 60 children facing similar respiratory ailments. Hospital beds are now in high demand, making it challenging for the medical staff, as explained by Shrestha.

Dr. Navin Dhakal, the coordinator of Children's Hospital, mentioned that children from Jhapa, Morang, Sunsari, Ilam, Panchthar, Khotang and Dhankuta seek medical assistance here.

The hospital's appeal is further heightened as it provides free treatment services to the economically disadvantaged. Four paediatricians are actively offering regular services, and the hospital has been selected by the Koshi state government to provide free treatment to children aged below 10 years.

PATAN HIGH COURT JUDGE MARASENI DIED OF CARDIAC ARREST

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Patan High Court judge Matrika Prasad Maraseni died of cardiac arrest Tuesday morning.

He was 56. He was rushed to the Kalanki-based Nepal National Hospital after he complained of health complications at 8:30 am today and was pronounced dead by the hospital amidst the treatment at 10:00 am, according to Court Spokesperson Tirtharaj Bhattarai.

He had joined the Patan High Court only a few days back following his promotion from the district judge. His last rites are to be performed at the Pashupati Aryaghat today itself, it is said.

15,820 TEMPORARY HOUSES BUILT IN THREE MONTHS IN JAJARKOT

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Jan. 30

Three months after the earthquake, 15,820 temporary shelters have been built in Jajarkot. Although 29,380 beneficiaries have signed an agreement for the first tranche, 28,433 quake victims have received their first tranche amount.

As of January 29, 14,091 beneficiaries have still been staying in the damaged houses as they could not get the funds in time. As the local level disaster management committee has been delaying the distribution of the assistance, the victims of the earthquake have not yet received the grant money sent to move the homeless people to a warm place as soon as their houses were destroyed by the earthquake.

The federal government had provided Rs. 1.34 billion to the local level fund, but the temporary housing construction work has been delayed because the grant has not been deposited in the beneficiary's account yet.

As of January 29, 29,380 victims have signed an agreement at the local level for the first tranche (Rs. 25,000), but only 28,433 beneficiaries have received the first instalment amount from the municipality, according to administrative officer Harish Chandra Sharma of the Municipality.

Five bridges under construction in Parbat section of Mid-Hill Highway

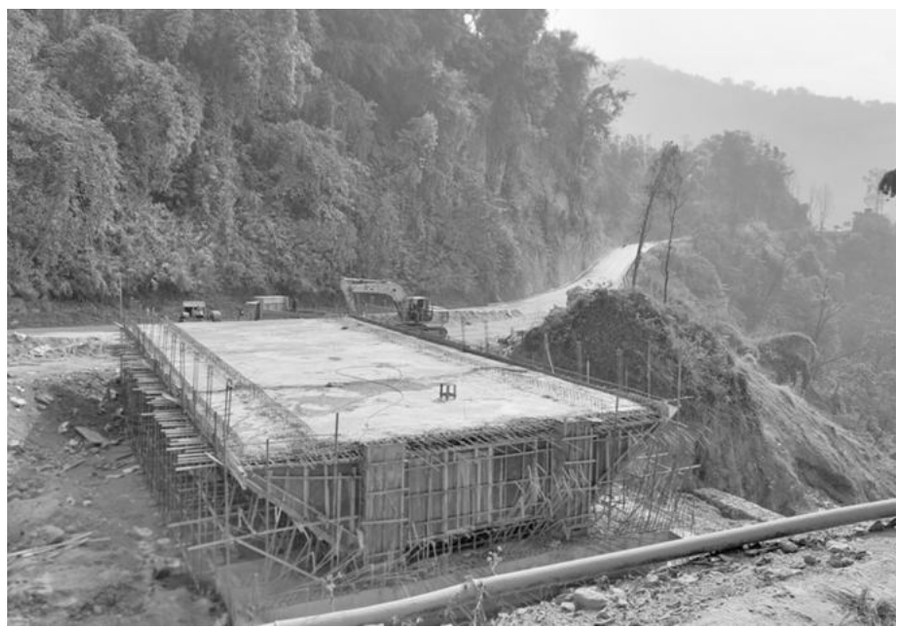


PHOTO: GANESH PAUDEL/TRN

An under-construction bridge in Parbat.

BY GANESH POUDEL
Parbat, Jan. 30

Altogether five motorable bridges are set to be constructed in the Parbat section of the Madhya Pahadi Lokmarg (Mid-Hill Highway) project, connecting the east and west regions. Three motorable bridges will be built in Modi Rural Municipality and two in Kushma Municipality along the Pokhara-Kushma road section of the highway.

During the rainy season, the Tamadi and Sundare rivers along the highway experienced flooding, resulting in road collapse and significant human and material damages.

During a flood in the Tamadi River in the last week of October 2021, three individuals lost their lives when their car was washed away. Similarly, two years ago, three people, along with their car, were swept away by floodwaters in the Sundare River.

According to the Madhya Pahadi Public Road Project Office Parbat, the construction of a bridge is going on over the Tamadi River. The office said that 70 per cent of the work on the bridge has been completed.

Engineer Dhiraj Dhakal from the office provided information that the cost estimation for the remaining three bridges was underway. He mentioned that a process was underway for the construction of motorable bridges over the Modi Khola, Paati Khola, and Sundare Khola.

According to him, a single-lane bridge will be constructed over the Modi Khola in Dimuwa and Paati Khola in Patichaur. Dhakal said that another bridge would be constructed near the single-lane bridge which was already in use in both places.

A 62-metre-long bridge will be constructed over the Modi Khola while two 52-metre-long bridges will be built on either side of the existing bridge at Patichour. Similarly, an 80-metre-long bridge is planned over the Sundare Khola in Dobilla. The anticipated cost for these four bridges is Rs. 52.9 million, with the contract awarded for Rs. 44.15 million.

The Pokhara-Kushma road was upgraded to two lanes from one-lane road two years ago as part of the Madhya Paahadi Lokmarga project. However, the office said that following the expansion of the road to two lanes, the existing one-lane bridge on the old structure had increased traffic pressure. As a result, there are plans to construct additional bridges to alleviate congestion and enhance traffic flow.

Nepal Airlines
NEPAL AIRLINES CORPORATION
CONTINUING AIRWORTHINESS MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT
Tribhuvan International Airport, Kathmandu, Nepal

Invitation for Sealed Quotation

(International Competitive Bidding)
Date of First Publication : 30th January 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC), Continuing Airworthiness Management Department Invites Sealed Quotation from PT6A-27 Engine Repair/Overhaul Organization (MROs) for exchange of its two (02) PT6A-27 core engines. The MROs are encouraged to visit the Notice/Announcement page in NAC Website: www.nepalairlines.com.np for detail information and downloading the Sealed Quotation Document.

Completed Sealed Quotation document should reach to the address given below within 15 (Fifteen) days before 17:00 hours local time from the first date of publication of this notice.

For further information, please contact :

Nepal Airlines Corporation
Continuing Airworthiness Management Department,
Tribhuvan International Airport
Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel: +977-1-4113085/4113209, Fax: +977-1-4470768
Email: dir.camd@nac.com.np, dydir.epd@nac.com.np
Website : http:// www.nepalairlines.com.np (Notice/Announcement page)

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Nobody cares how much you know,
until they know how much you care.
-- Theodore Roosevelt

EDITORIAL

Tribute To Martyrs

On Tuesday, Nepal observed the Martyrs' Day with a variety of programmes. Martyrs are remembered for their relentless struggles and sacrifices for the broader cause of the people and nation. Martyrs are those, who endure persecution and defy death while fighting for freedom, dignity, justice, democracy and equality. Nepal's political history is replete with great martyrs who fought against various autocratic systems, and inspired the commoners to wage ceaseless movements and revolutions to bring about transformative changes in the society. Therefore, it is the duty of all, including citizens and the government to pay tribute to them. On the day, great martyrs - Shukra Raj Shastri, Dharma Bhakta Mathema, Ganga Lal Shrestha and Dasharath Chand – were paid heartfelt respects as their sacrifices eventually fuelled a landmark revolution that toppled Rana rule in 1951, ten years after they were sentenced to death. Also called sat salko kranti, the 1951 revolution was considered the mother of all political movements and agitations launched in the subsequent years.

The day highlights the importance of the pledges made by the political parties, the government and civil society. This is done to make the dreams and views of the martyrs come true, so that they lead to lasting peace, good governance, development, and prosperity. During the martyrs' week, stories of wounded and martyrs' families facing economic hardships pour in. It's the government's role to strengthen, reach out to, and address their needs. Despite political parties honouring martyrs yearly, their actions seem disconnected from the ideals for which sacrifices were made. It may help nurture democracy, the rule of law and effective service delivery. However, challenges persist in consolidating public institutions essential for functional democracy.

Martyrs should not be declared on the basis of narrow political interests. This dishonours those who genuinely sacrificed for the country. While celebrating Martyrs Day, the government must ensure true heroes get proper recognition. Those who died for democracy and citizens' freedom deserve national respect. There was a shift in the manner in which the government regards martyrs. There should be unambiguous criteria to bestow the status of a martyr. The announcement of the monetary compensation for martyrs' families has led to unclear rules regarding eligibility and criteria. According to the Ministry of Home Affairs, the government has finalised the names of 11,419 martyrs, and their names have been officially published. Nevertheless, since the names of the rest of the 3,261 martyrs need public homage, their distinctive titles are yet to be known. Valuing the collective good, preserving democracy, and working for the people and the nation will truly honour martyrs.

Paying tribute to martyrs through words is meaningful, but tangible actions must follow the promise made in words. The commitment to the well-being of the martyrs' families should translate into policies, ensuring economic stability and social recognition. Political parties must set aside their differences for the larger cause of safeguarding the nation and democracy. This responsibility extends to citizens actively participating in the democratic process to ensure martyrs' sacrifices do not go in vain. In conclusion, Martyrs Day serves as more than a day of remembrance; it is a collective call to action. It urges the nation to uphold the values for which the martyrs sacrificed their lives. The stories of the martyrs should be passed down to future generations, not merely as historical narratives but as a source of inspiration for a nation striving for a better future.

Shun Catastrophising

DIXYA POUDEL

You step out of the house and a million things could go wrong. The traffic could get quite congested. You could lose track of directions if you are headed some place new. You might have to navigate a crowd, delaying your appointment. The scenarios could turn into a nightmare. Or, things might go according to your plans.

The stars and planets may align to turn your plans into reality. Events can either turn against your expectations or they can also go as per your plans. It is the fear of the former that leads to catastrophising.

Catastrophising occurs when you think negatively over future events. It is a result of incessant worries and overthinking that spirals into fear of the future events.

And fear tends to manifest in bodily systems as the stressed individual gets anxious thoughts, palpitations, rapid breathing and tense muscles. Catastrophising makes it difficult to make plans and fulfill them. However, there are steps you can follow to reduce it. According to Chhabi Adhikari, a Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP) specialist, you can turn to positive imaginations instead. Stepping outside of comfort zone can present a multitude of possible outcomes. Instead of fearing what could go contrary to your expectations, try to imagine positive outcomes.

It helps greatly to focus on the optimistic outcomes. The world is full of opportunities and not leaping out of your comfort zone can hamper your potential. For example, you may fear travelling to new places because you are socially anxious and imagine a plethora of negative outcomes. To tackle this, you could instead imagine good things such as making new friends and sight-seeing beautiful scenery.

The gist is that you can visualise things going according to your plans, and if the situation does go awry, you can learn lessons from it and face similar situations with self-assurance in the future.

Psychology Today defines NLP as 'a set of principles and techniques aimed at enhancing self-awareness, increasing confidence, building communication skills, and motivating positive social actions.' NLP works to change the thinking and belief patterns of a person. It can help obsessive thinking, overthinking, anxiety, phobias, depression, addiction, etc. The emphasis here is to plant in new positive beliefs in place of the old and outdated beliefs.

Initially created by John Grinder and Richard Bandler in the 1970s, NLP is increasingly used by life coaches who use its techniques to boost self-esteem in people with inferiority complex. However, it can also be used in successful people who want a better perspective and outlook to life.

As such, athletes, professionals and students can greatly benefit from the many advantages of NLP. NLP is a growing field in Nepal and Adhikari is quite optimistic about its future in Nepal which has lately seen a surge in mental health problems.

In conclusion, during difficult and adverse scenarios, ask yourself: What if? For example, what could happen if you stepped out of your comfort zone? What could go wrong? And then do it anyway. Do it despite the fear and anxiety. Do it despite the negative self-talk which creates false realities. You can change your outlook to life with the belief that you can tackle any troubles, even if the circumstances go wrong. Trust in your abilities to face adversities.

Diplomacy Key To Solve Myanmar Conflict

Chiranjibi Bhandari



Monojit Das



Myanmar is at a critical juncture. Following a military coup in February 2021, it had descended into vicious conflicts, triggering a complex web of political, economic, and humanitarian crises, with significant implications not only for Myanmar but also for regional stability in South Asia. Myanmar's history has been characterised by military rule, economic isolationism, and sporadic attempts at democratic transition. The military, known as the Tatmadaw, has held power since 1962, with brief periods of civilian rule. Economic isolationism has led to Myanmar's near-total isolation from the international community.

In 2011, Myanmar has boarded upon a series of reforms, particularly political, economic and administrative amendments, and economic reforms attracted foreign investment, fostering a period of relative growth and a decline in poverty rates. The democratic transition, led by Aung San Suu Kyi, brought hope for a more open and inclusive Myanmar. Conversely, the military's violent campaign against the Rohingya Muslim population tarnished Suu Kyi's international standing, leading to a loss of faith in her leadership. The military's contested claims of electoral fraud in the 2020 elections prompted the 2021 coup against the democratically elected government. The subsequent violent suppression of opposition protests caused human rights abuses, displacement, economic collapse, and a failing healthcare system.

Prevailing scenario

The ongoing scenario in Myanmar presents a complex and challenging situation that demands attention from the international community. The coordinated attacks, led by Three Brotherhood Alliance, comprising ethnic armed groups and pro-democracy fighters, against the military regime indicate a significant escalation in the conflict in the areas near the Chinese borders. The violence has forced hundreds of Myanmar residents to seek refuge in neighbouring countries, including India and other South Asian Countries, adding strain to an already tense situation.

India, sharing a border with Myanmar, is directly affected by the ethnic and religious unrest. The existing tensions between the Meitei and Kuki communities in Manipur area, coupled with the influx of refugees from Myanmar, pose considerable challenges to India's security and stability. The porous borders create a complex environment where issues such as cross-border crimes, drug trafficking and insurgent activities become prevalent. The threat to neighbouring countries extends beyond immediate security concerns. The potential for the conflict to spread to other South Asian nations is a looming danger.

The influx of refugees, coupled with the issue of drug trafficking, particularly opium, seriously threatens the youth in the region. The destabilisation of Myanmar could create a ripple effect, affecting the overall peace and security of South Asia. Now, the situation has become trickier as the rebels have also started advancing and taking areas under their control which they are terming as freedom from the junta rule, resulting in many soldiers moving to neighbouring countries for shelter.

> Diplomatic efforts should focus on engaging with all stakeholders, including the military rulers, opposition forces, and ethnic groups, to find a negotiated settlement that respects democratic principles and human rights.

The international response to the crisis has been underwhelming, with Western nations imposing sanctions, condemning human rights abuses, and urging regional organisations like ASEAN to intervene. The military's actions have drawn condemnation from the UN, foreign governments, and rights organisations. Sanctions have been imposed, and calls for intervention continue. The US has taken a tough approach, imposing sanctions on individuals and military companies. The Biden administration has slammed human rights abuses, supporting the National Unity Government, and granting protected status to Myanmar nationals in the US.

The reluctance for direct intervention is influenced by Myanmar's historical economic isolation, lack of substantial foreign investment, and the geostrategic interests of some global powers in supporting the military junta. China's economic and diplomatic influence, especially through the Belt and Road Initiative, makes it a key player in Myanmar's stability.

Coordinated efforts

The challenges faced by Myanmar are multifaceted, rooted in historical conflicts between various ethnic groups and the struggle for democracy. The military rule, which persisted for many decades, is considered to have perpetuated grievances and socio-political divisions. The current resistance against the military rule is a manifestation of the people's desire for democratic governance and an end to its dominance. The future of Myanmar hinges on concerted international efforts to address the root causes of the crisis, promote stability, and pave the way for a democratic and prosperous nation. The consequences of inaction extend beyond Myanmar's borders, impacting the broader South Asian region. At the moment, immediate and sustained humanitarian aid is crucial to alleviate the suffering of the Myanmar people. Access to healthcare, food, and necessities must be prioritized to mitigate the impact of the crisis.

The international community, including regional powers and organisations, should collaborate to address the crisis in Myanmar. International actors should advocate for the restoration of democracy in Myanmar, emphasizing the importance of inclusive governance, human rights, and political stability. Coordinated efforts are needed to facilitate dialogue, provide humanitarian assistance, and press for a peaceful resolution. Also, diplomatic efforts should focus on engaging with all stakeholders, including the military rulers, opposition forces, and ethnic groups, to find a negotiated settlement that respects democratic principles and human rights.

(Bhandari is an Assistant Professor at Department of Conflict, Peace and Development Studies, T. U and Das is an executive editor of Indian Aerospace and Defence News.)

Check Abuse Of Artificial Intelligence

Namrata Sharma



INSIGHT

As science advances and the digital age has taken over the daily life styles of humans all over the world, new forms of crimes are advancing. Computers have now become a lifeline for people's livelihoods. As people are relying on computers as a tool of their earning, communicating and entertaining, it is now becoming a potential threat of controlling several aspects of human lives including a source of various crimes. This is something that needs to be taught to all during basic education so that they are aware of the threats and can protect themselves as far as possible.

Last week the media all over the world was abuzz with a digital crime committed against one of the most popular celebrities on earth. Taylor Swift is a 34-year-old American singer and song writer who started working since the age of 14 and is one of the most popular personalities covered by media globally. Her songwriting, artistry and entrepreneurship is known to have influenced the music industry. She is a role model for youth around the world and universities offer courses on her work. On Wednesday 24, 2024, this popular individual became the subject of a crime which is now recognised as the most dangerous form of crime during this digital age. Artificial Intelligence (AI)-generated sexually explicit images of Taylor Swift was circulated on social media sites, gaining more traction on X, formerly known as Twitter.

According to Aljazeera, one image of the megastar was seen 47 million times during the approximately 17 hours it was live on X before it was removed on Thursday. Artificial Intelligence (AI) is now becoming a household name which many do not understand but which probably has started affecting all. AI is the technology that enables a computer to think or act in a more human way. Computers take in information from its surroundings and give responses based on what it learns or senses. According to a BBC site, AI affects the way we live, work and have fun and sometimes without us even realising it. As the digital age is advancing, technology is becoming more and more advanced. Machines are now made to think and this enables them to learn from their mistakes and change how they approach a particular subject the next time.

Deepfake technologies

Robots are the most common examples of AI demonstration and some scientists are even trying to teach robots about feelings and emotions. The devices that have become household necessities like the mobiles, video games etc are now very much dependent on AI technology and most of us are now passing our days without realising what influences they have on us. One simple example of AI influence in our daily lives is how this technology is used by our mobile phones, social media and the entertainment companies like Netflix. They are attuned to sense our preferences. Thus our devices get flooded with services and products that we may want or unknowingly start using even when we do not have the need to do so. Together with the advance of Artificial Intelligence, deepfake technologies are advancing too.

> Unfortunately, while wrongly used, AI has caused several misinformation which has had adverse impact on individuals and several social and political causes.

In this 21st century, deepfakes use a form of artificial intelligence called deep learning to make images of fake events thus known as deepfake. This technology has been used in the past to share fake videos where world leaders are shown to be saying and doing things that are not true and celebrities have been faked as pornography stars. According to the site IEEE Spectrum, deepfake technology can seamlessly stitch anyone in the world into a video or photo they never actually participated in. Such capabilities have existed for decades and several unpleasant fake incidents have been circulated. This technology can be used in a positive way with consent from the relevant sources to advance the work of entertainment and documentation and save time, money and energy.

Unfortunately, while wrongly used, AI has caused several misinformation which has had adverse impact on individuals and several social and political causes. According to Associated Press news agency, the deepfake-detecting group Reality Defender tracked down dozens of unique images of Taylor Swift that spread to millions of people across the internet before removing it. X has banned searches for Swift and queries relating to the photos. Deepfakes can be very sophisticated and difficult to identify as being fake, but there are some with poor quality visuals which can be identified easily. There are AI tools like Midjourney, Deepfakes web and DALL-E available to users for free or at low fee which are used to generate images which could hamper certain causes and individuals.

Women in target

A report by Sensity AI, an intelligence company focussed on detecting deepfakes, states that more than 96 per cent of deepfakes images currently online are of a pornographic nature, and nearly all of them target women. A study conducted by the Dawes Centre for Future Crime highlights the fact that there is potential misuse of AI technology for criminal purposes. It mentions that while the AI has the potential to revolutionise various industries, its misuse poses significant challenges to the society.

With the advance of science and technology, laws need to be formulated which will protect innocent citizens from unforeseen crimes. There also needs to be an awareness created among people to understand what AI actually is and how it could be used by powerful people in their favour. For now, the fans of Taylor Swift are protesting against the use of AI to tarnish her image. Celebrities like Swift are global icons who have created history in their work and contribution to not only their country but also around the world. There needs to be a mechanism to stop them from being harassed.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate. namrata1964@yahoo.com Twitter handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 31, 1974

Dhanusha Public Health Office

Janakpurdham, Jan 30: Dhanusha district public helath office has been opened in the locak Janaki Hospital, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Need To Upgrade Road In Parbat



This is in reference to a news report 'A news report "*Dilapidated road creates problems in orange supply*" published in this daily on Monday. It clearly draws an attention a critical issue that is adversely affecting the agricultural community in Jaljala Rural Municipality-1, Banskharka, Parbat district.

The farmers of this region, despite producing oranges worth millions of rupees, are facing insurmountable challenges in transporting their produce to the market due to the deplorable condition of the Baribeni-Bagar-Banskharka road. The road, which is the lifeline for the transportation of these valuable agricultural goods, is in the urgent need of upgradation.

The situation is particularly dire for large vehicles, which are unable to reach the orange gardens owing to the road's dilapidated condition. This has compelled the farmers to use smaller vehicles to transport oranges up to the Beni-Maldhunga road, from where the products are shifted to larger vehicles. It is, therefore, the authorities should work in earnest to improve road infrastructure in Parbat to solve the problems of the affected community.

Hari Thapa Magar
Pokhara

TAILPIECE

A devoted wife had spent her lifetime taking care of her husband. Now he had been slipping in and out of a coma for several months, yet she stayed by his bedside every single day.

When he came to senses, he motioned for her to come near him.

As she sat by him, he said, "You know what? You have been with me all through the bad times. When I got fired, you were there to support me. When my business failed, you were there. When I got shot, you were by my side. When we lost the house, you gave me support. When my health started failing, you were still by my side. You know what?"

"What dear?" she asks gently.

"I think you bring me bad luck."

Pakistani court convicts jailed ex-PM Imran Khan of revealing secrets ahead of elections

AP
Islamabad, Jan. 30

A Pakistani court convicted former Prime Minister Imran Khan of revealing official secrets on Tuesday and sentenced him to 10 years — the latest in a slew of legal cases that supporters say are meant to sideline the imprisoned former cricket star just days ahead of parliamentary elections.

The Islamist politician, who was ousted in a no-confidence vote in 2022, is not on the ballot because he is already serving a three-year prison term — and more than 150 other cases are still pending against him.

He nonetheless remains a potent political force because of his grassroots following and anti-establishment rhetoric.

However, Pakistan saw violent demonstrations after Khan's arrest last year, and authorities have cracked down on his supporters and party since then, making them wary of staging rallies.

The Feb. 8 elections come at a sensitive time in Pakistan, which is mired in an economic crisis that Khan's successor, Shehbaz Sharif, has struggled to manage. Sharif was only able to get a bailout from the International Monetary Fund by agreeing to a substantial increase in tariffs on gas and electricity that led to alarming price hikes on everyday goods and made his party unpopular.

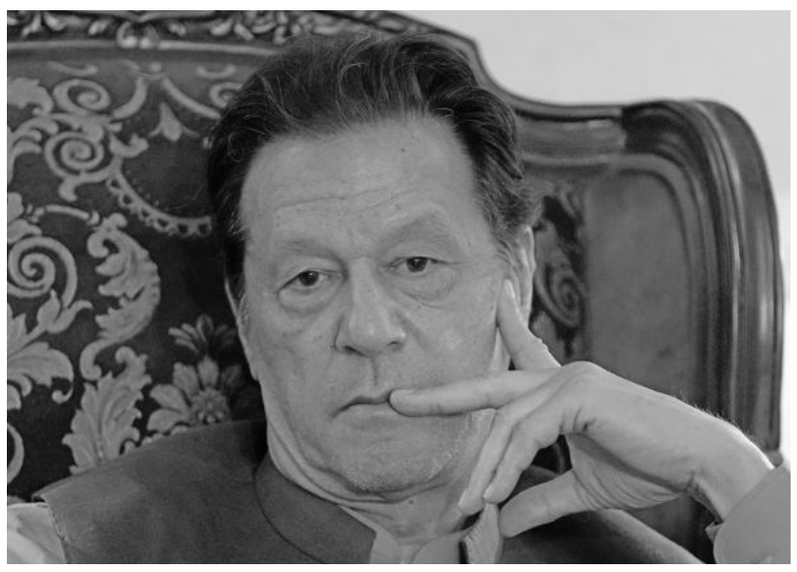


PHOTO: AP

Pakistan's former Prime Minister Imran Khan listens to a member of the media during a talk with reporters regarding the current political situation and the ongoing cases against him at his residence in Lahore, Pakistan, on Aug. 3, 2023.

On Tuesday, Khan was convicted in what is popularly known as the cipher case, in which he was accused of exposing state secrets by waving a confidential document at a rally. The document has not been made public but is believed to be diplomatic correspondence between the Pakistani ambassador to Washington and the Foreign Ministry in Islamabad.

Khan claimed the document was proof he was being threatened and that his ouster was a U.S. conspiracy, allegedly executed by the military and the government in Pakistan. American and Pakistani officials have denied the claim.

A special court at the prison in the garrison city of Rawalpindi where Khan is being held announced the verdict, according to Zulfiqar Bukhari, chief spokesman for Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party, or PTI.

A senior official in the party, Shah Mahmood Qureshi, who was accused of manipulating the contents of the diplomatic cable to gain political advantage, was also convicted and received a 10-year sentence.

Khan has maintained his innocence, saying he didn't disclose the exact contents of the cable. His party dismissed the trial as a sham, and his legal team plans to appeal the conviction before the Islamabad High Court on Wednesday.

Other charges against Khan range from contempt of court to terrorism and inciting violence.

Despite discontent with the government, analysts say turnout in the upcoming election may remain low since Khan is the only one in his party who had the charisma to attract the masses.

Pakistan's human rights commission has said there is little chance of a free and fair parliamentary election since so many candidates from Khan's party have been rejected.

Khan's party said in a statement that it stands with Khan and Qureshi, "who defended Pakistan and stood for real independence." It described the proceedings as a "sham trial" and said the judge did not even allow Khan's and Qureshi's lawyers to defend them.

However, the party asked his supporters to remain peaceful and not resort to violence.

Ukraine's gains could be reversed if no more US aid: Blinken

AFP
USA, Jan. 30

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken warned Monday that Ukraine's gains over two years of fighting were all in doubt without new US funding, as NATO's chief visited to lobby Congress.

Tens of billions of dollars in US aid has been sent to Ukraine since the invasion in February 2022, but Republican lawmakers have grown reluctant to keep supporting Kyiv, saying it lacks a clear end game as the fighting against President Vladimir Putin's forces grinds on.

As NATO Secretary-General Jens Stoltenberg made the case on a visit to Washington, Blinken offered an increasingly dire picture of Ukraine's prospects without US approval of the so-called supplemental funding.

"Without it, simply put, everything that Ukrainians achieved and that we've helped them achieve will be in jeopardy," Blinken told a joint news conference with Stoltenberg.

President Joe Biden has asked Congress to approve $61 billion in new aid to Ukraine.

But the talks have bogged down as Republican lawmakers – furious over record flows of migrants over the US border with Mexico – demand major changes in immigration and border control policy in exchange for approving more money for Ukraine.

Stoltenberg said he would meet US lawmakers on Tuesday and make the case that support for Ukraine was "in our own security interest."

"It will be a tragedy for Ukrainians if President Putin wins but it will also make the world more dangerous and all of us more insecure," Stoltenberg said.

"It will embolden other authoritarian leaders – not only President Putin, but also North Korea, Iran and China to use force," he said.

With many Republicans focused on opposing China, Stoltenberg said: "Today it's Ukraine; tomorrow it could be Taiwan."

US and NATO officials have acknowledged limited gains in a counteroffensive launched by Ukraine last year.

But Stoltenberg said that Ukrainians in the longer term have defied expectations, taking back half of the territory seized by Russia which had expected a swift takeover.



PHOTO: AFP

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken (R) and NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg participate in a joint press conference at the State Department on January 29, 2024 in Washington, DC.

ISRAELI UNDERCOVER FORCES DRESSED AS WOMEN AND MEDICS STORM WEST BANK HOSPITAL

AP
West Bank, Jan. 30

Israeli forces disguised as civilian women and medical workers stormed a hospital Tuesday in the occupied West Bank, killing three Palestinian militants in a dramatic raid that underscored how deadly violence has spilled into the territory from the war in Gaza.

The Palestinian Health Ministry said Israeli forces opened fire inside the wards of the Ibn Sina Hospital in the town of Jenin. The ministry condemned the raid and called on the international community to pressure Israel's military to halt such operations in hospitals. A hospital spokesperson said there was no exchange of fire, indicating that it was a targeted killing.

The military said the militants were using the hospital as a hideout, without providing evidence. It alleged that one of those targeted in the raid had transferred weapons and ammunition to others for a planned attack, purportedly inspired by the Hamas assault on southern Israel on Oct. 7 that triggered the war in Gaza.

Footage said to be security camera video from the hospital that circulated on social media showed about a dozen undercover forces, most of them armed, dressed as women with Muslim headscarves or hospital staff in scrubs or white doctor's coats.

Northern Ireland political party agrees to end 2-year boycott

AP
London, Jan. 30

Northern Ireland's largest British unionist party has agreed to end a boycott that left the region's people without a power-sharing administration for two years and rattled the foundations of the 25-year-old peace. The breakthrough could see the shuttered Belfast government restored within days.

After a marathon late-night meeting, Democratic Unionist Party leader Jeffrey Donaldson said Tuesday that the party's executive had backed proposals to return to the government. He said agreements reached with the U.K. government in London "provide a basis for our party to nominate members to the Northern Ireland Executive, thus seeing the restoration of the locally elected institutions."

The breakthrough came after the U.K. government last week gave Northern Ireland politicians until Feb. 8 to restore the Northern Ireland Assembly and executive or face new elections.

"All the conditions are in place for the Assembly to return," Northern Ireland Secretary Chris Heaton-Harris said. "The parties entitled to form an executive are meeting today to discuss these matters, and I hope to be able to finalize this deal with the political parties as soon as possible."

The DUP walked out in February 2022 in a dispute over post-Brexit trade rules. Ever since, it has refused to return to the government with the Irish nationalist party Sinn Fein. Under power-sharing rules established as part of Northern Ireland's peace process, the administration must include both British unionists and Irish nationalists.



The walkout left Northern Ireland's 1.9 million people without a functioning administration to make key decisions as the cost of living soared and backlogs strained the creaking public health system. Amid mounting public frustration, teachers, nurses and other public sector workers staged a 24-hour strike this month calling on politicians to return to the government and give them a long-delayed pay raise.

The British government has agreed to give Northern Ireland more than 3 billion pounds ($3.8 billion) for its public services, but only if the executive in Belfast gets back up and running.

The political impasse in Northern Ireland stems from the United Kingdom's decision to leave the European Union and its borderless trading bloc after decades of membership. The DUP quit the government in opposition to new trade rules put in place after the U.K. left the EU in 2020 that imposed customs checks and other hurdles on goods moving to Northern Ireland from the rest of the U.K.

The checks were imposed to maintain an open border between the north and its EU neighbor, the Republic of Ireland, a key pillar of the peace process that ended decades of violence in Northern Ireland.

PRISM

3 dogs rescued from canal

California: Firefighters and sheriff's deputies in California came to the rescue of three dogs found stranded in a canal with steep walls.

The Tulare County Sheriff's Office said deputies responded alongside Tulare County Fire personnel when three German shepherds were found trapped in the Friant Kern Canal near Avenue 128. "The dogs tried to climb out on their own, but slid back down the steep walls," the sheriff's office said in a Facebook post.

Employees from Brosamer & Wall were on the scene first and were able to keep the dogs from fleeing down the canal until rescuers arrived.

Newborn white shark caught on camera in wild

Marine researchers in California said a newborn great white shark was caught on camera in the wild for the first time.

The University of California said wildlife filmmaker Carlos Gauna and UC Riverside biology doctoral student Phillip Sternes were in waters near Santa Barbara when they captured drone footage of the 5-foot-long shark pup.

The pup was entirely white, contrasting with the color of adult great whites, which are white on the bottom and gray on top. "We enlarged the images, put them in slow motion, and realized the white layer was being shed from the body as it was swimming," Sternes said in a news release.

(AP)

Brazil, facing calls for reparations, wrangles with its painful legacy of slavery

AP
Rio De Janeiro, Jan. 30

The executive manager for institutional relations at a Brazilian state bank took the microphone before roughly 150 people at a forum on slavery's legacy in his country, which kidnapped more Africans for forced labor than any other nation.

"Today's Bank of Brazil asks Black people for forgiveness," André Machado said to the mostly Black audience at the Portela samba school in Rio de Janeiro.

"Directly or indirectly, all of Brazilian society should apologize to Black people for that sad moment in our history," he said, reading a statement to audience members who sat watching from plastic chairs, their eyes fixed upon him.

Brazil — where more than half the population self-identifies as Black or biracial — has long resisted reckoning with its past. That reluctance has started loosening.



PHOTO: AP

Models wear outfits designed by students from Afro-Brazilian communities at a subway station as part of Black Consciousness Awareness Month, in Sao Paulo, Brazil, Nov. 19, 2021.

Public prosecutors have begun probing Bank of Brazil, Latin America's second-largest financial institution by assets, with $380 billion, for its historical links to the slave trade. Their investigation could yield a recommendation, an agreement or filing of legal action, and they invited Bank of Brazil to start a dialogue with Black people at the Portela school in the working-class Madureira neighborhood.

Ghyslaine Almeida e Cunha, a spiritual leader of the Afro-Brazilian religion Umbanda, traveled from the Amazonian city of Belem for what she called "an historic moment." She welcomed the apology and announcement of measures, though the bank stopped short of pledging compensation.

"I came to say – on Portela's sacred soil – that, yes, we do want reparations," said Cunha.

Brazil enslaved more people from Africa than any other country; nearly 5 million kidnapped Africans disembarked in Brazil, more than 12 times the number taken to mainland North America, according to estimates from the Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade database. Brazil was the last country in the Western Hemisphere to abolish slavery, in 1888.

Valongo Wharf in Rio, which UNESCO calls "the most important physical trace of the arrival of African slaves on the American continent," was only excavated in 2011.

Discrimination remains, and Black and biracial Brazilians are more likely to be poor, imprisoned and die violently. Fewer than a third of managerial positions are held by those groups, and they comprise one quarter of representatives in Brazil's Lower House of Congress.

On Dec. 7, a Senate committee heard experts arguing that Brazil needs to prioritize compensation. And when Carnival kicks off next week, a samba school parading before tens of thousands of spectators and millions more TV viewers will present the story of a Black man whose family is seeking reparations.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1578 – Eighty Years' War and Anglo-Spanish War:
1747 – The first venereal diseases clinic opens at London Lock Hospital.
1891 – History of Portugal: The first attempt at a Portuguese republican revolution breaks out in the northern city of Porto.
1915 – World War I: Germany is the first to make large-scale use of poison gas in warfare in the Battle of Bolimów against Russia.
1918 – Finnish Civil War: The Suinula massacre, which changes the nature of the war in a more hostile direction, takes place in Kangasala.
1966 – The Soviet Union launches the unmanned Luna 9 spacecraft as part of the Luna program.
2001 – Two Japan Airlines planes nearly collide over Suruga Bay in Japan.
2020 – The United Kingdom's membership within the European Union ceases in accordance with Article 50, after 47 years of being a member state.

DEUBA NOMINATES FOUR MEMBERS TO NC JANAJATI FEDERATION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

President of the Nepali Congress Sher Bahadur Deuba has nominated four additional members to the Central Ad hoc Working Committee of the Nepal Democratic Janajati Federation led by Om Bahadur Gharti Magar.

The newly nominated members include Amir Lama Moktan from Bara, Arjun Kumar Gurung from Sindhuli, Indramaya Lama from Chitwan and Sanuram Ghale from Dhading, according to a statement issued by the party's chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel.

These individuals are expected to bring diverse backgrounds and experiences to the Federation, reflecting a commitment to a broad representation of tribal communities. The Federation plays a crucial role in addressing the concerns and advocating for the rights of tribal tribes in Nepal.

Deuba's decision to expand the Central Ad Hoc Working Committee aligns with the party's dedication to fostering inclusivity and ensuring that the voices of all communities are heard.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Former President Bidya Devi Bhandari releasing a book titled 'Samsad Ma KP Sharma Oli' at a function in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

CIAA FILES CORRUPTION CASE AGAINST BHATTARAI

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) filed a corruption case against Min Bahadur Bhattarai, Department Officer of the Ministry of Industry, Tourism, Forest and Environment of Madhes Province in Dhanusha and former Land Revenue Officer at Land Reform and Management Office in Lalitpur.

The CIAA filed the case at the Special Court, Kathmandu on Tuesday accusing Bhattarai of illegally acquiring assets and properties worth Rs. 42.9 million while serving as a civil servant.

During the examination of Bhattarai's income and expenditure from August 10, 1997 (when he entered civil service) till Jun 13, 2022 (last cut-off date), it was revealed that his total income was Rs. 59,467,148 while expenditure was Rs. 102,392,288.

The CIAA demanded that he should be fined Rs. 42.9 million and punished in accordance with the Prevention of the Corruption Act 1960 and 2002.

Meanwhile, the CIAA has also made Bhattarai's wife Jhuna Kumari Kathet as a defendant in the case.

It has demanded to confiscate assets in the name of Bhattarai and his wife equal to the fine amount.

PM calls for...

"Let's prepare to register more bills as soon as the parliamentary session begins. The chief secretary should follow up. The ministry should bring the bill in coordination with all the ministries and with good preparation. This time parliament should be given business in an orderly manner," he said.

Speaking on the occasion, Chief Secretary, Dr. Baikunth Aryal, directed the MoLJPA to make necessary preparations for the bills, saying that bills that have undergone legal examination and financial liability should be sent to the parliament quickly.

Likewise, Secretary of the Ministry, Udaya Raj Sapkota, said that the Ministry has done the necessary homework for the bills to be presented in the next session of the parliament and some of them would be presented at the beginning of the session.

Fast Track...

Under the project, construction of structures such as sub-base, air engineering, sewerage, retaining walls and service roads are being constructed in various sections of the Expressway.

So far, the project has acquired 4,776 ropani land of different individuals while 396 ropani of land is yet to be acquired. Similarly, according to the approved environmental impact assessment report, the project has to cut 38,664 trees but so far 28,646 trees have been cut down.

On May 4, 2017, the government had given the Nepali Army to complete the construction of the project starting from Kathmandu to Nijgadh in Bara within four years.

As per the agreement, the contractor was given a deadline of four years to complete the project construction. In September 2022, the new deadline was set for November, 2024. And again, the deadline has been extended till April, 2027.

Sah who transacted Rs. 1.49bn through cryptocurrency is in police net

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30



Illegal online gambling and cryptocurrency-based trading in Nepal is still going on unabated. It was revealed when a man arrested on Tuesday was found to have transacted Rs. 1.49 billion through the illegal means in two years.

The Kathmandu Crime Investigation Office on Tuesday arrested one of the cryptocurrency traders for illegally transferring money to online gamblers.

The police arrested 26-year-old Dumbar Sah, a resident of Dumri of Rajbiraj Municipality-10 in Saptari district. He used to load money through various means for online gambling, fraud and cryptocurrency, a dematralised currency.

The police investigation revealed that Sah alone had transferred Rs. 1.49 billion for online gambling and other illegal transactions in two years since 2021 through his company.

The police found that at least 34 people were cheated in the case. It has been found that Sah and his group illegally load money for online gambling and cheated people by sending parcels to different people through social media such as WhatsApp, Facebook and Imo.

It has also been revealed from the investigation that funds were being sent for illegal online gambling at various stages from Udgam Venture Capital, the company run by Sah.

Sah used to send money illegally when other people were looking for it, said SSP and Chief of the Office Somendra Singh Rathore at a press conference held on Tuesday.

Sah was found to be sending money in cash, crypto currency and bank transfer with interest for online gambling and fraud, said police.

The Office has also informed that Mithilesh Kumar Mandal, who was associated with Sah, used to buy and sell cash and cryptocurrencies.

Sah had opened four bank accounts in the name of Udgam Venture Capital for illegal money transactions, SSP Rathore said.

It has been found that Sah has transacted Rs. 916 million from those four accounts alone. He did this work from July 2022 to the end of June 2023.

Apart from this, it was found that Sah has opened 11 accounts in different banks in his own name and had transacted Rs. 583 million from those accounts. These transactions were also found to have taken place from June 2021 to June 2023.

It was found that Sah had transacted Rs. 1.49 billion in two years from the company's four accounts and his 11 accounts, police claimed.

Police investigation revealed that Sah was involved in buying and selling cryptocurrencies, transferring them to others and handling accounts for illegal activities including online gambling.

Bagmati civilisation action plan discussed

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

The High Powered Committee for Integrated Development of the Bagmati Civilisation under the Ministry of Urban Development on Monday organised a final discussion with experts and related ministry officials regarding the 20-year Bagmati Action Plan (2024-2044).

The action plan has been prepared with the overall vision for the restoration and conservation of the Bagmati River system and defined goals, objectives, and activities for each of the three zones, said Chakravarti Kanth, Project Director of the High Powered Committee for Integrated Development of the Bagmati Civilization (HPCIDBC).

During the programme, experts presented their vision and inputs to the draft Action Plan which is going to be finalised soon.

The action plan aims to maintain and enhance environmental services in the conservation zone, preserve the river ecosystem in the peri-urban zone, and focus on restoration in the urban zone. It also aims to preserve cultural heritage.

The activities and actions are proposed under three broad sectors -- River Conservation and Management, Cultural/Civilization Rehabilitation, and River/Water Quality and Quantity Improvement, Kanth informed.

According to the draft action plan, certain activities which are valid in all the zones are included. These activities are either common or associated with knowledge management that will help build the capacity of the HPCIDBC and other agencies and bolster the restoration and conservation of the Bagmati River and its tributaries.

This action plan has also incorporated the priority activities recommended by the previous action plan.

The actions for the conservation zone prioritise ecotourism promotion through cycling/hiking trails, water source conservation; groundwater recharge enhancement through rainwater storage/harvesting ponds and water reservoir dams, sustainable land use management through terrace improvement, promotion of organic farming; relocation of some settlements; gully control and sediment trapping; and reclamation, rehabilitation, and preservation of cultural heritage.

Similarly, the actions for peri-urban and urban zones prioritize green development with recreational facilities along the river corridor; implementation of Right of River Way to conserve river areas, river training works with bioengineering, development of corridor transport systems along rivers; management of sewerage to prevent direct disposal into the river through construction of interceptors and WWTPs, control of direct disposal of solid waste by strict law implementation; sustainable land use management; and reclamation, rehabilitation, and preservation of cultural heritage.

Nepal's corruption index improves...

The countries with strong rule of law and well-functioning democratic institutions often sit at the top of the index. Democratic countries tend to greatly outperform authoritarian regimes when controlling corruption – full democracies have a CPI average of 73, flawed democracies have one of 48 and non-democratic regimes just 32.

However, the top 25 countries in the index make up just over 10 per cent of all people. "Corruption therefore remains a challenge that directly or indirectly harms most people," said the TI.

The CPI ranks 180 countries and territories by their perceived levels of public-sector corruption according to experts and businesspeople. It relies on 13 independent data sources and uses a scale of zero to 100, where zero is highly corrupt and 100 is very clean.

The TI has maintained that the fight for justice and the fight against corruption go hand in hand, where the justice system is unable to uphold the rule of law, corruption thrives. At the same time, where corruption is the norm, access to justice is often hindered for the most vulnerable, and justice institutions may be captured by political, economic or special interest groups.

According to it, there has been a global decline in justice and the rule of law since 2016. The rise of authoritarianism in some countries contributes to this trend, and even in democratic contexts, the mechanisms that keep governments in check have weakened.

"Governments across the political spectrum have undermined justice systems, restricted civic freedoms and relied on non-democratic strategies to address recent challenges, including the COVID-19 pandemic," read the report.

NC's community campaign begins in Madhes

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gaur, Jan. 30

The Nepali Congress campaign has begun in all wards across the eight districts of the Madhes province since Tuesday.

The NC's campaign christened "Let's go to the community, listen to the people" is taking place in all wards of the Madhes Province from January 30 to February 9. The objective is to engage with the community, gather expectations, and suggestions and address any concerns raised by the people.

Central committee members leading the campaign include Kiran Yadav in Parsa, Anil Rukta in Bara, Ajay Siwakoti in Rautahat, Ganesh Lama in Sarlahi, Padam Narayan Chaudhary in Mahottari, Rajiv Dhungana in Dhanusha, Amrit Aryal in Siraha and Lakshmi Khatiwada in Saptari. Nitesh Kumar Gupta, Head of Nepali Congress Madhes Province Publicity Department, announced the names of party leaders deployed for the campaign on Tuesday.

Gupta shared that the central representatives from the Nepali Congress would be visiting all wards of Madhes province while district committee members would conduct a campaign to understand the sentiments and opinions at every ward level. The aim is to listen to citizens' complaints, collect reports, and work towards resolving them. As part of this initiative, provincial members designated as Madhes Congress representatives have mobilised the district officials, city presidents, general committee members, general assembly representatives, former officials and party cadres in all wards.

Gupta highlighted that the decision to conduct the campaign in all wards was made during a meeting chaired by the eight district presidents of the Nepali Congress in Madhes Province.

Meteorologists give revised view on Valley weather

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

At a time when the people in the Kathmandu Valley have been eagerly awaiting the forecast rainfall, the meteorologists have again indicated otherwise.

According to them, the anticipated moisture from the Western System has dissipated, remaining concentrated only in the western part of the country.

According to Dr. Binod Pokharel, Associate Professor at the Central Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, Tribhuvan University, three forecast models show good precipitation in the western part of the country while Kathmandu may receive only light precipitation on Wednesday.

"Forecast models are very uncertain this year, and it has become difficult to forecast this time," he said.

Western Nepal is expected to experience its first winter rainfall on Wednesday and Thursday while the eastern part may witness cloudy conditions, and the high mountainous regions may receive light snowfall, said Ganga Nagarkoti, a senior meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division under the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM).

Dr. Pokharel said that it was a fact that winter precipitation has decreased in recent years due to the overall weakness of the westerly system.

According to DHM, there is a possibility of light to moderate snowfall in many places of the high mountainous and Himalayan regions of Sudurpashchim, Karnali and Gandaki Provinces from Tuesday to Thursday.

Likewise, some places of the high mountainous and Himalayan regions of Bagmati and Koshi Provinces may also receive rainfall, it said.

Due to the westerly system, there is a possibility of a slight decrease in temperature on Wednesday and Thursday.

On Tuesday, the temperature in Kathmandu was recorded at 3.8 degrees Celsius while the minimum temperature in Jumla was recorded at minus 5.3 degrees Celsius.

Russian opposition figure Kara-Murza is moved to another prison

AP
Tallinn, Estonia, Jan. 30

Lawyers for Russian opposition figure Vladimir Kara-Murza Jr., who is serving a 25-year sentence for treason, revealed Tuesday he has been transferred to another prison in Siberia and placed in solitary confinement again over an alleged minor infraction.

The move comes amid unrelenting pressure on Russian dissidents at home and abroad that has intensified significantly since President Vladimir Putin sent troops into Ukraine almost two years ago.

Kara-Murza, 42, had been held in a penal colony in the Omsk region, but his supporters said on Monday he apparently was no longer there.

One of his lawyers, Maria Eismont, told Russia's independent Novaya Gazeta newspaper on Tuesday that she received a letter from him in which he said he was transferred to Penal Colony No. 7 in the city of Omsk and placed in a restricted housing unit for at least four months. In the letter, a copy of which his other lawyer, Vadim Prokhorov, posted on Facebook, Kara-Murza said prison officials on Friday accused him of disobeying a command that he said wasn't even given to him.

"So now I'm in the IK-7 (penal colony), also in Omsk," Kara-Murza wrote. "It is a special regime colony, there is a special restricted housing unit facility for 'repeat violators' like me. I'm in solitary confinement, of course," he wrote, adding that he was "fine," had enough food and it was warm in the facility.

Kara-Murza, who twice survived poisonings that he blamed on Russian authorities, has rejected the charges against him as punishment for standing up to Putin and likened the proceedings to the show trials under Soviet dictator Josef Stalin.

According to his wife, Evgenia Kara-Murza, he spent the past four months in solitary confinement, a practice that has become common for Kremlin critics behind bars and is widely viewed as designed to put additional pressure on them.

DUDHKOSHI JALVIDYUT COMPANY LIMITED
(A subsidiary company of Nepal Electricity Authority)

Invitation For Bids and Notice of Consultative Meeting

Notices have been published for Invitation for Bids (IFB) for following works and Consultative Meeting of International Consultants' on following dates. As per the notices, Pre-Bid Meetings and Consultative Meeting will be held on the following date and time.

S.N.	Descriptions	Contract Identification No	First Date of Publication	Pre-Bid Meeting/ Consultative Meeting
1	Design and Build (incl. IEE Study) of Dudhkoshi River Motorable Bridge near Bhoje Gaon connecting Okhaldhunga and Khotang Districts	DKSHEP/ NCB/2080/81-01	11 January 2024	01 February 2024, 2:00 PM
2	Consultative Meeting with Prospective International Consulting Firms/Companies/Organizations for Consultancy Services for Project Construction Supervision of DKSHEP.	-	19 January 2024	07 February 2024 3:00 to 5:00 PM (NST)
3	Construction of Bailey Bridge on Dudhkoshi River at Rabuwa Connecting Okhaldhunga and Khotang Districts	DKSHEP/ NCB/2080/81-02	28 January 2024	16 February 2024 1:00 PM
4	Construction of Prefab Buildings including other Works in Project's Camp at Lamidada, Khotang	DKSHEP/ NCB/2080/81-03	28 January 2024	16 February 2024 3:00 PM

Please visit **www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp** for more details for serial numbers 1, 3 and 4, and please visit **www.nea.org.np** for serial number 2.

Prithiviya Thapa wins Humanitarian Award at Mrs. World

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30



Nepal reached the semi-finals and secured the Humanitarian Award in the international competition for Mrs. World 2023, held in Las Vegas.

Mrs. Nepal World Prithiviya Thapa, the representative from Nepal, received the Humanitarian Award in the beauty pageant.

Thapa said that winning the Humanitarian Award, one of the seven titles in addition to the top title in Mrs. World, is a significant success.

She considers it a great achievement for Nepal, emphasising the importance of this accomplishment not only for herself but also for her country.

Thapa expressed optimism about Nepal's potential to win the Mrs. World title with increased preparation and participation, and she is returning to Nepal this week with the prestigious award.

Nisukant Jha, the president of Ribbon Entertainment, the organising body of Mrs. Nepal World, expressed their satisfaction with this achievement. He noted that this success marked Nepal's second representation at Mrs. World and winning a major award on this occasion is a source of pride for the country.

The title of Mrs. World 2023 was claimed by Germany's Julia Carolin, who is also a medical doctor and has made notable contributions to the treatment of children and senior citizens.

The competition featured women from 38 different countries, showcasing the beauty and talent of married individuals from over 57 countries worldwide.

Cinema halls to be shut on February 05

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

Nepal Motion Picture Association, the umbrella organisation of film halls, announced the closure of cinema halls nationwide on February 5.

In a press statement issued on Tuesday, the association declared the closure as a symbolic protest, demanding the abolition of what they consider to be unreasonable taxes.

The association alleges that the government has compelled the film sector to bear a tax burden exceeding 33 per cent under various tax categories.

The statement, released by the association's general secretary and spokesperson, Narendra Maharjan, asserts, "The film sector is obligated to pay over 33 per cent in taxes, encompassing value-added tax and corporate tax. In violation of the code prohibiting additional taxes, the imposition of film development fees, local entertainment taxes and various other levies has rendered the operation of the movie business impracticable." The association calls for the cancellation of other unjustifiable taxes, excluding value-added tax, and has decided to close cinema houses nationwide for one day on coming Monday, as a symbolic gesture.

According to the association, 450 theaters were I operation across the country before the establishment of the Film Development Board, but now their number has come down to 150.

According to the press statement, the film industry has experienced a severe downturn primarily attributed to the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic.

Additionally, the association asserts that the burden of government-imposed taxes has further exacerbated the challenges, making it impractical to sustain business operations in the current scenario.

Judge denies Cher temporary conservatorship she's seeking over son

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 30



A judge on Monday rejected Cher's request that her adult son be put into a court conservatorship controlling his money. The Oscar- and Grammy-winning singer and actor had argued in a petition that 47-year-old Elijah Blue Allman's large payments from the trust of his late father, rocker Gregg Allman, are putting him in danger because of his struggles with mental health and substance abuse.

But Los Angeles Superior Court Judge Jessica A. Uzcategui was not convinced that a conservatorship was urgently needed and declined the petition, though she will still consider a larger, long-term conservatorship at a hearing in March.

Cher observed the hearing remotely. She appeared on a large screen in the courtroom throughout, but did not take part in the arguments.

Allman was in the courtroom with his his attorneys, who acknowledged his previous struggles but argued that he is in a good place now, attending meetings, getting treatment and reconciling with his previously estranged wife. "We are thrilled that the court saw that he does not need a temporary conservatorship," Allman's lawyer said as he stood alongside him outside the courthouse. "He's got a lot of support, he's doing great."

Cher's attorneys argued that the support Allman was getting was from people who tell him what he wants to hear and downplay the size of his problems. They said his current apparent sobriety and mental health were illusory. They said he suffers from bipolar disorder, has been recently homeless, and that having large amounts of money might lead to access to drugs that could endanger his life.

Blue and his attorneys have consistently argued since the petition was first filed in December that none of this is true.

Uzcategui had already signaled at a hearing on January 5 that she wasn't inclined to establish a conservatorship, delaying the decision until Monday because documents had not been shared in time with Allman's attorneys.

Cher's attorneys said that she was not necessarily seeking any direct control over Allman's money, and would be happy to have a court-appointed fiduciary manage his finances. They did not immediately reply to a request for comment on the judge's decision.

'Dhaniramko Goru' to be staged in Pokhara



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kaski, Jan. 30

The play 'Dhaniramko Goru,' presented by Padma Prem Theatre, is scheduled to be staged in Pokhara from February 1 to 10.

Directed by Kapil Sharma, the play was written by Kedarnath Sharma.

Sabitra Pathak (Sabu), the director of Padma Prem Theatre, announced that the play would be staged at Padma Prem Theatre in Pokhara every day from February 1 to 10 at 5 pm, with an additional show on Saturday at 1 pm.

Writer Sharma emphasised that the play is a pure representation of Nepaliness, and 'Dhaniramko Goru' reflects the story of the people.

The narrative aims to shed lights on the genuine problems faced by rural society and farmers, added Sharma.

Dil Prasad Gurung takes on the main character in this 75-minute-long play, portraying the role of Dhaniram.

Joining Gurung, the cast includes Bibhu Bhushal, Sabu Pathak, Jyoti Hamal, Shitala Adhikari, Suman Karki, Ramhari Adhikari, Dibya Amrit, Arjun Gurung, Pawan BK, and Abhishek Bhusal. Established on September 15 last year, Padma Prem Theater is presenting its first play with 'Dhaniramko Goru.'

FELLINI'S MUSE AND ITALIAN FILM ICON SANDRA MILO DIES AT 90

AP
New York, Jan. 30

Sandra Milo, an icon of Italian cinema who played a key role in Federico Fellini's "8½" and later became his muse, died Monday, her family said. She was 90.

Milo, noted for her distinctive high-pitched voice, died in her sleep at home in Rome, surrounded by her family and beloved dogs Jim and Lady, according to a statement from the family carried by state-run RAI television.

"Ciao Diva!" the Venice Biennale posted on social media, calling Milo an "unforgettable and versatile" actor both in comedy and drama.

Born Elena Salvatrice Greco, Milo had her break in Roberto Rossellini's 1959 film "Il generale Della Rovere (General Della Rovere)." She went onto star with some of the greats of Italy's post-war film industry, including Alberto Sordi and Marcello Mastroianni, with whom she appeared in the Oscar-winning "8½."

Milo played Carla, the mistress to Mastroianni's film director Guido.

Fellini later cast her alongside his own wife in the 1965 film "Juliet of the Spirits."

Two decades later Milo recounted their 17-year secret love affair in her indirectly autobiographical book, "Caro Federico."

Milo became a fixture on Italian television as a talk show host, and in 1990 was the victim of an on-air prank that went down in Italian television history as a tasteless precursor to reality TV's "Punk'd."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You can get your mojo back with a little help from your friends. You might be struggling with your public persona, career, or nearby authority figures -- it could even involve your parents.

Taurus: Responsible work is a good way to avoid drama. In particular, if you're struggling with a student, co-worker, or roommate, it'll be hard to avoid them. They could be focused on you in a way that causes you irritation.

Gemini: Emotional turbulence in your connections with others may hit you with the force of a tsunami! There's no need to flee immediately, but you might find yourself craving a solo vacation or alone time to decompress.

Cancer: You're standing firm. You may have to commit to a promise that you made recently, or it's possible that someone is trying to push your boundaries. Specifics aside, you won't back down from your truth.

Leo: You can shift how others see you. They may have underestimated you or written you off in the past, when you knew that you had more to give -- they just weren't seeing it!

Virgo: Your passion is being amplified. You're not ready to surrender or give up, even if you have to work around the clock to make it happen. The tenacity of a warrior can be yours, even if you're working online or indoors -- let the universe embolden you to do whatever it takes.

Libra: Other people might not understand what you need from them. They could be living their lives the way that they want to, while you're making sacrifices for them. That's not an even exchange!.

Scorpio: You are not alone, Scorpio. Loved ones, whether they're your biological family, found family, or even roommates, take heed of the ways that you're lifted up by the people who know you best.

Sagittarius: It may be harder to express yourself than normal. You might not be finding the right words to say, allowing the moment to pass by, neglecting to say anything.

Capricorn: Ambition can become cutthroat at any moment. You may feel like you're in your element and you're in boss mode, able to tell people what to do and when to do it, but you might be letting the power go to your head in this case.

Aquarius: You're sharing your feelings through words. It may be that someone hurt you in the past and you're telling them how you felt, or perhaps you hurt someone and you're asking them for forgiveness.

Pisces: Insecurities are valid, but they can be healed. It won't be easy, particularly if an issue of yours keeps getting triggered by someone else or yourself. Still, the cosmos is encouraging acceptance in a way that inspires.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Koshi ends winless drought in PM Cup defeating Lumbini in final group match

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30



PHOTO: BIKAS/TRN

Players of Koshi Province celebrates their win against Lumbini Province at Prime Minister Cup

Koshi Province was highly expected to end its campaign without a single win at the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament as it failed to win in eight of the nine group matches it played.

However, playing its final group match at TU International Cricket Ground on Tuesday, Koshi ended its winless drought defeating Lumbini Province by 16 runs. On the other hand, Lumbini, which was playing its second-to-last group match, failed bag its second victory in the tournament.

While Lumbini's bowlers did enough to restrict Koshi below 200 runs, the batting side could not deliver in the chase as it got bundled out in the 47th over at 156 runs.

Nar Sarki took four wickets, Bir Magar took three, Avishek Gautam took two and Krishna Karki took one for Lumbini. Three batsmen of Koshi, including opener Samir Karki and experienced Sujan Thapaliya, were sent back for a duck.

Captain Ankit Subedi fell only a run short of his half-century after getting caught in the 26th over while Saujan Ghimire also added 43 runs before getting struck leg-before in the 45th over as the last wicket for Koshi.

Desperate for at least one win in a tournament filled with failures for Koshi, the bowlers delivered when it mattered the most. Koshi used seven bowlers, with Meenash Thapa bowling only one over, to pressurise Lumbini throughout the chase.

After delivering with the bat, Saujan Ghimire also took three wickets with the ball. Avyash Timilsina, Kamal Khatri and Samir Karki also bagged two wickets each for Koshi.

Dilsad Ali was Lumbini's highest scorer with 32 off 64 followed by Birat Bhandari (28 off 60), Samrat Bhusal (26 off 27) and Krishna Karki (22 off 22). Six batsmen could not score in double figures for Lumbini as the team failed short of only 16 runs.

Lumbini faces finalist Nepal Police in its last group match at Mulpani on Wednesday. Police has remained unbeaten in the tournament and advanced to the final leading the group standings with 14 points from seven matches.

APF beat Sudup Paschim

On the other hand, Sudur Pashchim's hope of climbing to the top four was dashed by Armed Police Force (APF) Club in a match where the two teams did not even play for a joint 50 overs.

Electing to field first, APF bundled out Sudur Pashchim in the 17th over for only 87 runs. Three batsmen of Sudur Pashchim failed to open their accounts, including two who returned to the pavilion for a golden duck.

Chandan Ram was the main weapon for APF as he claimed a fifer in only seven overs; nevertheless, he was expensive with 51 runs.

Bhuvan Karki, who bowled 6.2 overs, bagged three wickets alongside a maiden over. Bowling only two overs, captain Rohit Paudel also took two wickets for the team.

Narayan Joshi stayed not out as the highest scorer for Sudur Pashchim with 31 off 25. The only other batsman to score in double figures for Sudur Pashchim was opener Khadak Bohora (24 off 33).

Nevertheless, the chase was not as easy as APF expected it to be. It only took APF 14.1 overs to score 89 but had to lose seven wickets.

Losing opener Lokesh Bam in the first over for six runs, Aasif Sheikh, Sumit Maharjan and Paudel joined him in the next eight overs after contributing 23 runs in total with the bat.

Sundeep Jora stayed not out as the team's highest scorer with 18 runs off 15 balls. He took the team to the win with Chandan Ram on the runner's end; meanwhile, Ram did not have to face any ball.

In 13 overs of bowling in turns, Dipak Chand and Naren Saud took four and three wickets respectively for Sudur Pashchim while Sher Malla, who bowled 1.1 overs, did not bag any.

The fifth place APF is now with 10 points from five wins and three defeats. AFP has still one match in hand.

After suffering fourth defeat Sudur Paschim is out of the title contention. Sudur Paschim, which also has one match left, has eight points from four wins and four defeats.

SNIPPETS

Uzbekistan reach Asian Cup last eight

Doha (AFP): Uzbekistan will face hosts and holders Qatar in the Asian Cup quarter-finals after highly rated Abbosbek Fayzullaev hit the winner in a 2-1 victory over Thailand on Tuesday. The Uzbeks have been touted as dark horses for the title and took the lead in the first half with a cool Azizbek Turgunboev finish through the legs of the goalkeeper. Thailand were the lowest-ranked team left at the tournament but they struck back just before the hour with an even better goal, from distance, by substitute Supachok Sarachat. Uzbekistan were the more accomplished team and went ahead again midway through the second half when 20-year-old CSKA Moscow winger Fayzullaev rolled the ball in from outside the box. This time Thailand had no reply, despite some late pressure.

Qatar booked their spot in the last eight on Monday with a 2-1 victory over Palestine. Palestine coach Makram Daboub said he was proud of his "champions" as their best Asian Cup came to an end in the last 16. Palestine were playing in the knockout rounds for the first time and, against the backdrop of the Israel-Hamas war in the Palestinian territory of Gaza, took a surprise first-half lead. Daboub said his players "gave everything despite the very difficult circumstances". "I can't ask any more of them -- they have honoured Palestinian football," he said.

Messi's Miami lose to Al-Hilal

Riyadh (AP): Lionel Messi and Inter Miami kicked off their tour of Saudi Arabia by losing to Al-Hilal 4-3 on Monday.The Major League Soccer team is playing two games in the oil-rich kingdom as part of its preseason preparations, but even Messi could not inspire it to victory in Riyadh.

While Messi got on the score sheet with a second-half penalty, Malcom came up with the decisive goal to win the match in the 88th. A potential showdown with Cristiano Ronaldo's Al-Nasser on Thursday is the most anticipated match.

De Rossi's Roma revival continues

Rome (AP): Daniele De Rossi's dream start as the Roma boss continued when they earned a second straight win by 2-1 over Salernitana in Serie A on Monday. De Rossi took over from manager Jose Mourinho on Jan. 16 and won his first game against Verona four days later. His second win came thanks to second-half goals from Paulo Dybala and Lorenzo Pellegrini. The capital club rose three places in the standings to fifth.

Mayoral tops Liga scoring chart

Madrid (AP): Borja Mayoral moved to the top of the Spanish league scoring chart with his 14th of the season as Getafe beat Granada 2-0 on Monday. The goal made Mayoral level with co-leaders Jude Bellingham of Real Madrid and Artem Dovbyk of Girona. Former Manchester United forward Mason Greenwood put the visitors up 1-0 after 20 minutes. Mayoral's goal 15 minutes later was even more fortunate as Batalla slipped in possession, allowing Mayoral to steal the ball in front of goal and tap it into the empty net.

Myrto Uzini missed a penalty for Granada 14 minutes into the second half on an unhappy night for the league's second-to-last club.

CHURCH BOYS FIX SEMIS DATE WITH ARMY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30

The four semi-finalists for the 23rd Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup have been finalised as Church Boys United Club defeated Nepal Police Club in the final quarter-final match of the tournament on Tuesday.

A solitary goal from Samir Tamang sent Church Boys, the club which won its maiden A-Division league title in June 2023, to the semis. Tamang scored the only goal of the match in the 73rd minute.

Nepal Police lost its quarter-final match against Church Boys for the second consecutive season as the first division league champions won 2-1 in the earlier edition.

Church Boys has now joined Three Star Club, Jawalakhel Youth Club and Tribhuwan Army Club in the semi-finals.

While Three Star and Jawalakhel will play the first semi-final match on January 31, Church Boys will face Tribhuwan Army on February 1. The final match for the Aaha! Rara Pokhara Gold Cup will be played on February 3.

Ashok to judge in Spain Taekwondo Championship

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 30



International Taekwondo Judge Ashok Khadka is set to participate in the Spain Taekwondo Championship as a jury member. The championship is scheduled to take place from February 2-4 in Alicante, Spain.

Ashok will be judging Kyorugi and Poomsae in the championship organized by the World Olympic Taekwondo Federation. He is a certified 2nd Class International Kyorugi Judge and a certified Taekwondo Referee of Poomsae.

Ashok, who is also the President of the Kathmandu Taekwondo Association, has judged more than 40 international competitions in various parts of the world, with 36 of them being world-ranking tournaments. He has been declared the best judge in the World Taekwondo Championship held in Bulgaria last year and other world ranking competitions held in Belgium, Sweden, and Australia.

He is one of the few Nepali taekwondo practitioners who have trained as a Para-referee from World Taekwondo. Ashok is a sixth dan taekwondo master and has trained more than 450 black belt players. He has also taught Taekwondo to over 5,000 people, and he is a 3rd Class Poomsae Coach.

Ashok has also won many medals as a player. He won the silver medal in the 17th Japan Open International Taekwondo Championship 2023. He has won gold medals in the 6th National Games, 3rd Korean Ambassadors National Taekwondo Championships, 8th World Taekwondo Expo 2014, 8th Motto Gold Coast Open International Taekwondo 2017 Australia, CTA Inter National Taekwondo, Hong Kong, and many more.

For his contribution to Taekwondo, the Nepal government has conferred Ashok with the National Sports Talent Award 2021, Citizen Gold Medal 2013, and Special Service Award 2014 and 2018. He has also received several awards from various national and international organizations.

HAALAND TO RETURN FOR CITY

AP
Manchester, Jan. 30

Erling Haaland is available again for Manchester City after nearly two months out with a foot injury, manager Pep Guardiola said Tuesday.

The Norway striker will return to the squad for City's English Premier League game at home to Burnley on Wednesday.

Guardiola didn't say whether Haaland would start the match at Etihad Stadium.

"For the first time, he is back," Guardiola said. "Two months out is a long time but he feels good ... apparently tomorrow he will be with all of us."

The 23-year-old Haaland's last game was at Aston Villa on Dec. 6, since when he has suffered with stress on the bone of his foot.

Guardiola has managed the minutes of Kevin De Bruyne since the playmaker's return from his own long-term injury — a hamstring problem that required surgery and a five-month absence.

De Bruyne has made three straight appearances as a substitute but Guardiola said Haaland, the top scorer in the league last season, might not need to be eased back so carefully.

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:52 am, Sunset at 5:43 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Generally cloudy in Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with the hilly region and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at a few places of Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at one or two places of hilly regions of rest of the country. Chances of light to moderate snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at one or two places of high hilly and mountainous regions of rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 16-18 Rain Probability: 10%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.8	3.1	0.0
Dipayal	21.7	3.8	0.0
Dhangadi	23.0	6.8	0.0
Birendranagar	22.4	4.3	0.0
Nepalgunj	23.8	7.4	0.0
Jumla	13.9	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	21.0	6.4	0.0
Pokhara	19.8	8.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.9	5.2	0.0
Simara	23.1	6.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.5	3.8	0.0
Okhaldhunga	14.1	5.5	0.0
Taplejung	13.6	4.6	Traces
Dhankuta	21.0	6.8	0.0
Biratnagar	24.4	6.5	0.0
Jomsom	7.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	24.3	11.7	0.0*
Lumle	14.0	4.5	0.0*
Janakpur	24.8	6.4	0.0*
Jiri	12.7	-0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 31, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.68	Rs. 133.28
Euro	1	Rs. 143.87	Rs. 144.52
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.22	Rs. 168.99
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.77	Rs. 154.46
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.52	Rs. 87.92
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.94	Rs. 99.39
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.06	Rs.99.50
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.01	Rs. 9.05
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.48	Rs. 18.56
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.56
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.75	Rs. 3.77
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.12	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.98	Rs. 10.03
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.75	Rs. 12.80
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.30	Rs. 19.39
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.98	Rs. 17.05
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.24	Rs. 433.19
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.90	Rs. 353.50

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Still alive - Ivory Coast's roller-coaster AFCON ride goes on

AFP
Abidjan, Jan. 30



Seemingly dead, buried and completely humiliated just a few days ago, Ivory Coast's Africa Cup of Nations dream somehow remains alive and there is suddenly a sense of optimism after the Elephants beat reigning champions Senegal to reach the quarter-finals.

The Ivorians won Monday's last-16 tie 5-4 on penalties after a 1-1 draw in capital Yamoussoukro, with Franck Kessie scoring the decisive spot-kick.

The victory led to wild celebrations in Abidjan, the country's economic capital, where fans danced in the streets and set off fireworks. "Ivorians don't mess around, we won," one supporter, Lydie Tagro, told AFP amid bedlam on the streets of Ivory Coast's largest city.

Yet the team was in a mess just a week ago, seemingly set for a group-stage exit from their own tournament. Now they are into the quarter-finals and eyeing a third continental title after seeing off one of the favourites to lift the trophy.

Interim coach Emerse Fae had described it as a "resurrection" even before their meeting with Senegal, for which the Ivorian squad prepared by visiting Yamoussoukro's Notre Dame de la Paix, the world's largest basilica.

The last week has been a roller-coaster ride for his team and for supporters in this football-mad West African country. A 4-0 defeat by Equatorial Guinea last Monday, January 22, their heaviest-ever home loss, meant they finished third in their group.

Yet they squeezed through with the worst record of the four best third-placed sides to qualify, rescued because their neighbours Ghana somehow conceded two goals in stoppage time to draw 2-2 with Mozambique.

Before their qualification for the last 16 was confirmed, the Ivorian Football Federation decided to dismiss veteran French coach Jean-Louis Gasset.

Fae, the former Elephants midfielder who played alongside Didier Drogba and the Toure brothers in the side that lost the 2006 AFCON final, was put in interim charge.

Yet that was only by default after a sensational bid to bring back former boss Herve Renard — the coach of the France women's side — was rejected by his current employers.

Many Ivorians thought their team stood no chance against the might of Sadio Mane's Senegal, but they showed the mental strength that had been lacking in the group stage as they recovered from the loss of an early goal to fight back.

Kessie, the former AC Milan and Barcelona midfielder now playing for Al Ahli in Saudi Arabia, was one of those dropped from the team by Fae but he ended up as the hero.

It was Kessie who equalised with a late penalty in normal time before then scoring the winning kick in the shoot-out.

Earlier on Monday, Cape Verde won an AFCON knockout tie for the first time in their history as a late Ryan Mendes penalty gave them a 1-0 victory over Mauritania in Abidjan.

The tie was drifting towards extra time when Cape Verde won a spot-kick as substitute Gilson Tavares Benchimol was brought down in the box by Mauritania goalkeeper Babacar Niasse.

Captain Mendes then converted with just two minutes of the 90 remaining to break the resistance of a Mauritania side appearing in the knockout phase for the first time.

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